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SHARED TRADITION

Cultural ties, rooted in spirituality

Buddhist relics of Indian origin are set to be enshrined among the 108 'stupas of enlightenment' along Mau Chhu River in Bhutan's Gelephu town

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What safeguards exist against social media takedowns?

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Lula da Silva, the Pele of Brazilian politics

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Britain open to apologising for slavery, says PM Burnham

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INSIDE



Mojtaba warns U.S., Israel against launching attacks

TEHRAN
Following threats by the U.S. and Israel to resume strikes against Iran after elections, Supreme Leader of the Islamic Republic Mojtaba Khamenei said on Saturday that any attack will be met with geographically unrestricted response. » PAGE 12

Meitei, Naga groups hold rallies in Manipur

IMPHAL
An umbrella body of Meitei groups held a rally in Imphal on Saturday seeking protection for indigenous people and the scrapping of the Suspension of Operations pact with militant groups. Naga civil bodies also held marches in Chandel and Senapati districts. » PAGE 3

Hundreds march against attacks on bookstalls

KOLKATA
Hundreds of people walked holding books in their hands at a rally in Kolkata on Saturday protesting against attacks on books and bookstalls, blamed on right-wing groups and the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP). » PAGE 5

Polish President accuses PM of court takeover

WARSAW
Polish President Karol Nawrocki on Saturday accused Prime Minister Donald Tusk of staging a takeover of the country's top court after the head of the court, an ally of the previous far-right government, was suspended. » PAGE 12

INDIA bloc adopts 'motion to impeach' CEC

- Opposition levels six charges against Gyanesh Kumar as it holds symbolic Parliament session
- Rahul Gandhi warns that officials involved in electoral irregularities will face accountability
- Mallikarjun Kharge calls for the repeal of the law granting lifelong immunity to the CEC

Sandeep Phukan
NEW DELHI

The Indian National Developmental, Inclusive Alliance (INDIA) on Saturday carried out a symbolic "public impeachment" of Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar, unanimously adopting a "motion" by a show of hands.

The Opposition bloc levelled six charges against Mr. Kumar, including conspiring with the ruling BJP to steal elections, disenfranchising 13.2 crore voters through the special intensive revision (SIR) exercises, and acting at the behest of Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Union Home Minister Amit Shah.

Leader of Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi described the "impeachment" as a "political weapon" aimed at all those who had "colluded" to destroy the votes of the Indian people. He asserted that Mr. Kumar should not only be removed from office but also tried in a court of law for treason. The Opposition was compelled to hold a public impeachment because "every other institution and institutional direction" was closed to it, Mr. Gandhi said, warning that those involved in irregularities "would not escape accountability and would eventually have to face the representatives of the people".

The "motion" was moved by Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge, whose official residence served as the venue for the public impeachment. The proceedings were modelled on those of Parliament, replicating the setting of the Lok Sabha, with former Speaker Meira Kumar presiding over the session.

'A political weapon'
Mr. Gandhi said the unprecedented gathering in the garden of Mr. Kharge's residence may seem "absurd" and reflected the closure of institutional avenues available to the Opposition.

In a pointed warning to officials working under the CEC, Mr. Gandhi said they could not expect legal protection to shield them indefinitely.

"Mr. Modi and Mr. Shah might be on top. We will deal with them, but you are their instruments, and so you are our first target," he said. He also cautioned officials not to underestimate the public response in a time of political change.

Mr. Gandhi alleged that 13.3 crore votes had been deleted from electoral rolls, accounting for nearly 15% of India's electorate, while the difference between the Opposition and the winning side in the 2024 Lok Sabha election was only three percentage points.

Earlier, moving the motion, Mr. Kharge accused the CEC of overseeing a conspiracy to manipulate elections, deleting voters' names, changing Form 6 without parliamentary oversight, centralising electoral rolls through ERONET/ECINET, excluding the other two Election Commissioners from decision-making, and acting at the behest of the Prime Minister and the Home Minister. He said 193 Opposition MPs had submitted notices in both Houses of Parliament seeking Mr. Kumar's removal seven months ago, but their proposals had been rejected.

The present exercise, he said, was intended to defend the dignity of a constitutional institution and restore public confidence in the Election Commission.

"We have no personal enmity with the CEC. We want the Election Commission to work impartially and maintain the trust of the people in it," he said, adding that the law which gives lifelong immunity to the CEC should be repealed.

Mamata Trinamool Congress leader Sagarika Ghose alleged that the 2026 West Bengal Assembly election was "stolen" by deleting eligible voters from the electoral rolls, while her colleague, Mahua Moitra, claimed that 71% of those deleted from the Bengal electoral rolls were Muslims and 51% were women.

Communist Party of India (Marxist) MP John Brittas said the SIR exercise was hollowing out universal adult franchise by forcing even elected representatives to establish their eligibility to vote.

Noting that he had personally attended two hearings to establish that he was an eligible voter, he asked: "If this is the situation of an MP, a public representative, what would be the condition of the common man?"

'Pawn on a chess board'
CPI MP P. Sandosh Kumar said the country was witnessing a reversal of the democratic experiment undertaken during the first general election. "In a democracy, people elect the government. In SIR, the reverse is happening – the government is selecting the voters," he said.

Independent Rajya Sabha member Kapil Sibal described Mr. Kumar as a "pawn on a chess board" and argued that manipluting the electoral rolls electronically came under the definition of treason under criminal laws.

VOTERS RAISE QUESTIONS
» PAGE 4



Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge speaks during the symbolic 'impeachment' of CEC in New Delhi on Saturday. PTI

Democratic institutions being ridiculed, says BJP

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Accusing Opposition parties of repeatedly disrupting proceedings in the real Parliament, the Bharatiya Janata Party on Saturday said the Congress and its allies were ridiculing democratic institutions by staging a mock Parliament session.

FULL REPORT ON
» PAGE 4

Settling dust



Valiant effort: Workers spray water along a road in Delhi on Saturday to fight air pollution even as a spell of heavy rain on Friday gave the city its cleanest October day in four years with a 'satisfactory' air quality index reading. SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA (RELATED REPORT: PAGE 5)

Blind faith, fear can lead to authoritarianism: SC judge

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

Supreme Court judge Justice Ujjal Bhuyan said a society that accepts claims without evidence, fears questions and treats tradition as beyond question becomes vulnerable to misinformation, defenceless in the face of authoritarianism, and fails to reform unjust practices.

Justice Bhuyan said building a scientific temper enshrined in Article 51A of the Constitution should not be confined to laboratories but extend to the capacity of youths and students to think rationally as members of a civil and political society.

Attitude of inquiry
"All that you need is the capacity to think rationally; what you say or think must be based on reason. It [scientific temper] is an attitude of inquiry and openness to examination. It cannot happen overnight. The germination has to take place in the university," Justice Bhuyan said in his address at the University of Science and Technology, Meghalaya on Saturday .

The speech resonates after the nation saw widespread dissatisfaction among Gen Z over NEET 2026 paper leaks, student unrest in universities and a wave of agitations across premier institutions from IIT Bombay to multiple National Law Schools, followed by a demand to restore student union elections at Jamia Millia Islamia.

The judge said society should demand empirical evidence when public discourse relies on emotional resonance and unverified assertions. Students must acquire the habit of inquiry to see through misinformation.

'Destructive tendency'
"To inquire is to avoid accepting the very first explanation that comes our way; it tells us to look for reasons; and it trains the mind to search a little deeper than what appears at the surface. This is nothing else but the development of a scientific temper. This will protect the mind from prejudice and empower it to make independent thinking and choice possible," Justice Bhuyan said in his address.

The judge pointed out how society is willingly or unwillingly getting drawn into a "false narrative: the binary of 'us' and 'they'". He termed this a destructive tendency.

'Concept of we'
Justice Bhuyan said the narrative must shift from 'us' and 'they' to the 'we' of the Preamble to the Constitution of India, which starts with the expression 'We, the People of India'.

"This Constitutional concept of 'we' enables diversity to coexist with unity. Its genius lies in the fact that it does not seek to efface the differences; rather, it seeks to restore unity without demanding uniformity. It does not require that our individual identities should get subsumed in the larger whole," Justice Bhuyan said.



> All you need is the capacity to think rationally; what you say or think must be based on reason. It is an attitude of inquiry and openness to examination. It cannot happen overnight. The germination has to take place in the university
>
> JUSTICE UJJAL BHUYAN
> Supreme Court judge

Two foreign nationals die in pool of Bengaluru hotel

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

Two foreign nationals, a German and a Slovak, died following suspected electrocution in the swimming pool on the third floor of Conrad Hotel at Ulsoor in Bengaluru on Friday evening. The deceased have been identified as Alexander Maximilian Theiss, 57, a Lufthansa Airlines crew member, and Juraj Horvat, 45, a Slovak national working as a project manager with an IT company.

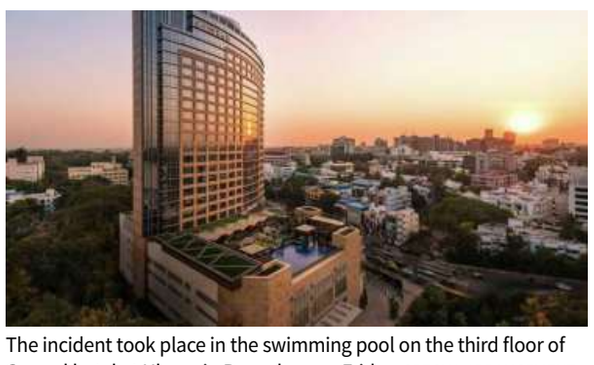
According to the police, two other persons sustained injuries while attempting to rescue the victims. They have been identified as Mathew Desantis, 41, an American tourist staying in the hotel, and Rahul Tiwari, 28, a pool attendant and lifeguard employed by Conrad Hotel. Both injured persons were shifted to a private hospital where they are undergoing treatment. They are said to be out of danger.

Bengaluru City Police Commissioner Seemant Kumar Singh said one of the victims reportedly came into contact with an electric current and collapsed. The second person, who attempted to rescue him, also suffered electric shock and died.

Preliminary assessment indicates that power leaked into the pool and there was a suspected short circuit.

Autopsy reports of the bodies of the two deceased and an Electrical Inspectorate inquiry report are awaited. Meanwhile, police registered a case against the hotel management for causing death due to negligence.

A spokesperson of the Conrad Hotel expressed condolences to the families of the deceased and said they were offering full support to the investigators.



The incident took place in the swimming pool on the third floor of Conrad hotel at Ulsoor in Bengaluru on Friday. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

INBRIEF



Telangana extends 'instant pension' to more beneficiaries

In a move aimed at providing financial security to women who lose their spouses, the Telangana government has extended the 'instant pension' facility to more categories of social security pensioners, enabling eligible women to receive pensions immediately following the death of their pensioner husbands. The decision will benefit the families of persons with disabilities, toddy tappers, handloom weavers, dialysis patients and those affected by HIV and filariasis.

Lone one-horned rhino at zoo in Thiruvananthapuram dies

Jadu, the lone one-horned rhinoceros at the Thiruvananthapuram zoo in Keralam and one of the main attractions of the facility for some three decades, died on Friday night. The rhino, affectionately called Shambhu by the zoo staff, was 39. Under treatment for old-age related ailments, he died of dilated cardiomyopathy. The average lifespan of a rhinoceros is around 35-40 years. Shambhu was transported from the State Zoological Park, Guwahati, Assam in 1993.

Man detained in Keralam for flying drone in sensitive area

The Kerala Police detained a Punjab native settled in Canada for flying a drone without the requisite permissions in the highly sensitive area near the Mattancherry synagogue on Friday. He was identified as Ashu Kumar Khanna. According to the FIR, Mr. Khanna flew the drone in an area comprising the synagogue, Coast Guard premises and INS Dronacharya, the Indian Navy's premier gunnery and missile training establishment. He was later released after being served a notice.

2,500 acres identified for land swap for Mekedatu project: Karnataka CM

The project, once implemented, would enable Karnataka to store 66 tmc of water, says Shivakumar; government hopes to make progress by the next Budget, he adds; T.N. has expressed apprehensions that it will affect the flow of Cauvery water

Press Trust of India
MANDYA



The Cauvery flows through a gorge at Mekedatu, near Kanakapura in Ramanagara district of Karnataka. K. MURALI KUMAR

Karnataka Chief Minister D.K. Shivakumar on Saturday said 2,500 acres of land had been identified as alternative land, including forest land, to facilitate the Mekedatu balancing reservoir project across the Cauvery river.

The project, once implemented, would enable Karnataka to store 66 tmc of water and regulate its release during difficult periods, benefiting farmers in Mandya and other Cauvery basin areas, the Chief Minister said.

He said the Deputy Commissioner of Mandya district had been appointed chairman of the committee overseeing the process, and officials had already held meetings on providing alternative land to the Forest Department.

"We have collectively decided to provide alternative land, including forest land, in lieu of the land required for the project. We have identified 2,500 acres so far and are in the process of identifying the remaining land," he said.

Mekedatu is a multi-purpose project proposed by Karnataka, which involves building a balancing reservoir near Kanakapura in Bengaluru South district.

The project is aimed at ensuring drinking water to Bengaluru and neighbouring areas; it can also generate 400 MW power, according to officials.

Importance of project

Explaining the importance of the project, Mr. Shivakumar said Karnataka was required to release 177 tmc of water downstream and the proposed reservoir would help regulate water releases.

Mr. Shivakumar said the State government would upload the details of the alternative land on the forest clearance portal and expected the necessary permissions to be granted thereafter. The government hopes to make progress by the next Budget, he added.

Tamil Nadu has raised apprehensions that the flow of Cauvery water into the State will be affected if the project takes shape.

"We will upload all the details of the land being provided, including the land particulars. Once we do that, they should grant the necessary permission," he said.

Noting that only around 500-odd acres of farmers' land would be acquired for the project, Mr. Shivakumar said the land acquisition process would be initiated.

SIT files FIR in PSC exam fraud case in Keralam

G. Anand
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

The Special Investigation Team (SIT) of the Crime Branch probing the suspected fraud in recruitment tests conducted by the Kerala State Public Service Commission (KPSC) for has registered an FIR against the independent constitutional body's chairperson M.R. Baiju and fellow members.

The FIR registered on October 28 indicts the chairperson and other members for criminal breach of trust and wrongful employment of their constitutionally sanctioned authority. It alleges that they tilted the playing field in favour of candidates owing allegiance to the CPI(M) by tweaking the rank list .

A.P. girl attacked with chainsaw in school

Hareesh P.
ANANTAPUR

A Class 10 girl is battling for life in a hospital after she was attacked with an electric chainsaw at her school at Raptadu in Anantapur district of Andhra Pradesh on Saturday. Another girl suffered minor injuries.

According to police and eyewitnesses, Hemanth, a close relative of the girl, barged into her classroom and started attacking her indiscriminately, leaving the students and the teacher in shock. The police later arrested him at Dharmavaram railway station.

The Raptadu Police registered cases under the SC/ST (Prevention of Atrocities) Act and on charges of attempted murder. The motive behind the attack is being probed.

Chief Minister N. Chandrababu Naidu has directed the police to ensure thorough investigation.

AIADMK chief slams TVK-led govt. in T.N. for 'administrative incompetence'

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

AIADMK general secretary Edappadi K. Palaniswami on Saturday criticised the Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam-led government for its "administrative incompetence".

Addressing a meeting in Maraimalai Nagar on the outskirts of Chennai amid the 55th formation day celebrations of his party, Mr. Palaniswami wondered what had been the achievement of the TVK-led government.

Even schemes launched by it, such as the marriage assistance scheme for women, were originally implemented by the previous AIADMK regime, which had provided the financial assistance along with gold for *thirumangalyam*. In view of "steep hike" in the prices of construction materials, infrastructure work had come to a halt.

After coming to power, the TVK regime had stated publicly that the State power utility was facing a debt of ₹2.47 lakh crore.

'Power rates'

This being the case, how could it justify the move to procure power at costlier rates, the AIADMK leader wondered.

"Rising" inflation, "growing" unemployment, "rampant availability" of drugs, "lack of security" for all sections of society, and law and order "deterioration" had marked the government's reign. Though the ruling party claimed that it had been running a "clean government," searches being conducted by the Directorate of Vigilance and Anti Corruption at several government offices led to the recovery of cash, giving the impression that bribery had been prevalent, Mr. Palaniswami argued.

'Protest against vote theft to be integrated with workers' issues'

The Hindu Bureau
KOZHIKODE

CPI(ML) Liberation general secretary Dipankar Bhattacharya has said that the ongoing protests by the INDIA bloc against alleged vote theft will be integrated with the concerns of the farmers and the working class.

He was addressing the media in Keralam on Saturday. Answering a question, Mr. Bhattacharya said there would be greater coordination between the ongoing struggles on the ground and INDIA bloc, which was initially launched as an electoral alliance.

"We, the Left parties, always pay very close attention to the farmers' issues. The biggest challenge before the Indian farmers now is the proposed India-U.S. trade deal, which, if finalised, will sound a death knell for Indian agriculture. The farmers will suffer enormously because they cannot compete with the American farmers who are backed by the U.S. state and its economy," he said.

Likewise, the workers had been fighting against the Labour Codes. "Earlier, whatever basic labour rights were promised, many of them were never really kept. Now with the Labour Codes, there is absolutely no concern for the labour welfare or any security of Indian workers. So we are with the working class," he added.

He also said that all INDIA bloc constituents would be participating in the protest rally planned on the Ram Lila grounds in New Delhi on Sunday.

Soaring at sunset



A young boy enjoys a swing as the sun dips below the horizon at Kava, near Malampuzha in Keralam on Saturday evening. K.K. MUSTAFAH

Naidu urges vigilance amid fresh cyclone prediction in A.P.

The Hindu Bureau
VIJAYAWADA

Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister N. Chandrababu Naidu has directed officials to expedite restoration works in the areas affected by Cyclone Arnab and called for a high alert in view of the threat of another cyclone.

With a depression over the southeast Bay of Bengal predicted to intensify into a cyclone by Sunday, moderate to heavy rainfall is likely in the south coastal Andhra and Rayalaseema regions on November 2, 3 and 4.

Reviewing relief and restoration measures in the cyclone-hit districts at the Real Time Governance Society (RTGS) Centre in the Secretariat on Saturday, he directed officials to monitor the movement of the depression every six hours and take appropriate measures based on its trajectory.

Mr. Naidu directed officials to urgently restore the protection wall at Kakinada, clear silt from canals in the Narsapuram and Katrenikona areas, and strengthen drainage systems in Konaseema and West Godavari districts to ensure the smooth flow of water.

He ordered compensation of ₹54,000 per hectare for damage to 1,293 hectares of coconut plantations and ₹1,500 for each uprooted coconut tree.

Keralam likely to receive rainfall from today

The Hindu Bureau
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

After a brief hiatus, the rainfall activity is set to resume in Keralam for a few days from Sunday under the influence of a weather system developing over the Bay of Bengal.

According to the India Meteorological Department (IMD), a low-pressure area formed over the South Andaman Sea and adjoining areas of the Andaman and Nicobar Islands is likely to intensify into a depression over the southeast Bay of Bengal and adjoining areas of the Andaman Sea and Andaman and Nicobar Islands on Saturday.

Probe finds TDB staff role in Sabarimala ghee scam

The Hindu Bureau
PATHANAMTHITTA

The Vigilance team probing the Sabarimala ghee scam has found that more Travancore Devaswom Board (TDB) employees were involved in the fraud, and that a portion of the proceeds from the sale of stolen ghee was distributed among them.

The prime accused, S.S. Binu, a transport contractor and alleged mastermind of the scam facilitated the diversion of the ghee, distributed ₹20 lakh among Devaswom employees.

Four-year-old boy killed in stray dog attack in Karnataka

The Hindu Bureau
KALABURAGI

A four-year-old boy died after being attacked by a stray dog in the Dariyapur locality of Housing Board Colony in Kalaburagi, Karnataka on Friday evening. Thirteen other people were reportedly bitten by the same dog during their morning walk on Saturday.

The deceased has been identified as Manoj, son of Sharanappa, a native of Jambaga village. Sharanappa works as a watchman in the city.

The incident occurred when Manoj was playing outside his house. He sustained serious injuries in the attack and was rushed to the District Hospital, where he died of injuries.

The same stray dog, suspected to be rabid, reportedly attacked 13 people who were out morning walk on Saturday. All the injured are undergoing treatment at the District Hospital. A case has been registered against the Kalaburagi City Corporation.

The incidents have triggered anger among residents, who have urged the civic authorities to take measures to control the stray dog menace.

Youth escapes police custody while being transported to prison in T.N.

The Hindu Bureau
COIMBATORE



An intensive search operation has been launched in coordination with the Coimbatore City and District police. FILE PHOTO

A 25-year-old who was convicted of theft in Bengaluru a few months ago escaped from police custody for the second time in Coimbatore in the early hours of Saturday.

Raghavan had first escaped from custody on June 19 while being transported from Coimbatore to Bengaluru. Following the incident, the Annur police registered a case against him. He was arrested in Bhavani on Friday in connection with the case. Raghavan was produced before a magistrate at the Fast Track Court in Coimbatore around 11 p.m. on Friday and remanded in judicial custody.

He managed to escape from police custody around 12.40 a.m. on Saturday by pushing the police personnel escorting him, just before he could be taken through the entrance gate of the Coimbatore Central Prison for admission.

Based on a complaint lodged by the Annur police, the Race Course police have registered a case in connection with his second escape.

An intensive search operation has been launched in coordination with the Coimbatore City and District police.

Special teams have been formed under the supervision of senior police officers.

Four police personnel responsible for escorting him have been placed under suspension for lapses in duty.

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Quad plans Indo-Pacific AI push; U.S. to assist in mineral recycling

In their third meeting this year, Foreign Ministers of India, Australia, Japan and the U.S. express intent to provide trusted AI access across Indo-Pacific; Jaishankar calls for deeper cooperation on energy security, counter-terrorism, maritime issues

Press Trust of India
WASHINGTON

Foreign Ministers of Quad grouping on Saturday expressed their intent to provide $85 million in technical assistance to expand access to trusted Artificial Intelligence across the Indo-Pacific even as the U.S. committed to provide $10 million for recycling critical minerals in India and ASEAN countries.

The Quad deliberations, hosted by U.S. Secretary of State Marco Rubio on the sidelines of the G20 Foreign Ministers' Meeting in Atlanta, U.S., were attended by External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar, Australian Foreign Minister Penny Wong, and Japan's Foreign Minister Toshimitsu Motegi.

Participating in the Quad Foreign Ministers' Meeting, Mr. Jaishankar said he spoke about countering non-market practices and increased economic stresses in the Indo-Pacific region.


External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar with Japan's Foreign Minister Toshimitsu Motegi, U.S. Secretary of State Marco Rubio and Australia's Foreign Minister Penny Wong in Atlanta, U.S., on Saturday. AFP

Mr. Jaishankar said he highlighted the importance of maintaining stability, driving prosperity and ensuring freedom of choice as continuing commitments in the Indo-Pacific.

The Minister also underscored taking forward agreements on counter-terrorism, maritime security and capacity building to enhance resilience and contribute to peace and stability.

In a joint statement, the Quad Ministers announced the first-ever Quad Business Leaders' Forum to foster greater ties across public and private sectors, including the promotion of commercial deals in key sectors.

The Ministers also said the second Quad-at-Sea Ship Observer mission was successfully undertaken from September 25 to October 7 with representatives from all four countries aboard an Indian Coast Guard Offshore Patrol Vessel.

This was the third Quad Foreign Ministers' Meeting held this year. Earlier, the Ministers met in New Delhi in May and in Manila in July.

Quad Leaders' Summit

Moves are underway to convene a Quad Leaders' Summit, hosted by U.S. President Donald Trump in mid-November.

In a joint statement issued after the meeting, the Ministers said they were looking forward to the Quad Leaders' Summit on the sidelines of the ASEAN-East Asia meetings in the Philippines in mid-November.

"I think hopefully when our leaders meet, in November, they will be able to announce some more concrete steps," Mr. Rubio said.

Four including Myanmar national arrested by ED in 'narco-hawala' probe

Devesh K. Pandey
NEW DELHI

The Enforcement Directorate has arrested four more accused, including a Myanmar citizen, in connection with an international cross-border "narco-hawala" network, following a recent multi-agency crackdown on the network.

As part of Operation Trident, simultaneous raids were earlier carried out at 38 locations across Assam, Mizoram, and Manipur, leading to the arrest of 18 accused persons and detection of ₹100 crore in "hawala" transactions on October 23.

The agency has uncovered financial records purportedly showing that drug suppliers in Myanmar were also paid in kind.

In the latest arrests by the ED, the agency took into custody Myanmar national Thangcintuang alias Chintuang; Lalrammuana of Champhai district in Mizoram, Jabrul Haque from Sribhumi and Abu Saleh Md Saif Uddin from Karimganj in Assam. They were lodged in jail in connection with cases registered by the Narcotics Control Bureau. The ED produced them before a local court and secured their 48-hour custody for interrogation.


18 accused persons were arrested in earlier raids as part of Operation Trident.

According to the agency, Chintuang was the Myanmar-based supplier of the 49.1 kg methamphetamine consignment seized on August, 2025, while Lalrammuana was the main handler and Jabrul Haque its intended receiver at the Damchhera-Kanhmun border. Abu Saleh was allegedly the operator whose account received ₹11.44 crore, including ₹6.67 crore in cash, and fed the Champhai "hawala" accounts.

The ED allegedly seized cash books, registers and notebooks containing handwritten accounts of another accused Zenngaihniang's "hawala" business during searches at her premises in Churachandpur town. "The records reflect a regular currency-exchange and 'hawala' operation in which Indian currencies were received in cash and in bank accounts from persons in different parts of India, converted into Myanmari Kyat, and paid out to persons in Myanmar," it alleged.

"Seven signed ₹10 notes, suspected to have been used as tokens for identifying the recipients of 'hawala' payments, and documents of an immovable property purchased for ₹60 lakh in the name of Zenngaihniang alias Taniang were also seized," said the agency.

Efforts on to bring back bodies from Uttarakhand crash site

The Hindu Bureau
CHAMOLI

Teams deployed to recover the bodies of six persons, who died in a helicopter crash in Joshimath, reached the accident site on Saturday, and an intensive operation is under way to bring them back to the nearest road from the remote location, officials said.

A privately run helicopter carrying pilgrims from Badrinath crashed into a hillside in Joshimath in Uttarakhand amid overcast conditions on Friday afternoon, killing all six persons on board. The bodies of the pilot and the five pilgrims from Karnataka were found on Friday in the vicinity of the wreckage in Chai village. The operation was suspended on Friday due to darkness, the presence of wild animals, and difficult terrain.

The teams trekked along difficult mountain paths from the direction of Pandukeshwar to reach the wreckage and are now working to safely recover the mortal remains.

The multi-agency operation began early Saturday morning but Chamoli district administration officials said the crash site is located in a highly inaccessible, high-altitude mountainous region and transporting them to the nearest road poses a significant challenge.

A team from the Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA) and officials from the Uttarakhand administration also conducted an aerial survey of the site where the helicopter crashed. According to sources, the team has returned to Dehradun following the aerial survey and will prepare an investigation report on the incident.

Chief Minister Pushkar Singh Dhami said that orders have been issued to investigate and determine the cause of the accident.

Co-pilot must

Meanwhile, UCADA on Saturday made it mandatory for helicopters operating on pilgrimage routes to carry a co-pilot. In another decision, UCADA has also made it compulsory for all pilots to submit a report to the authorities after every flight, detailing weather conditions and other important operational information.

(With inputs from PTI)

Meitei, Naga groups hold rallies in Manipur; demand end to SoO pact

Press Trust of India
IMPHAL

An umbrella body of Meitei groups held a massive rally in Manipur's capital Imphal on Saturday seeking protection for indigenous people and the scrapping of the Suspension of Operations (SoO) agreement with militant groups.

Naga civil bodies also held marches in Chandel and Senapati districts, supporting the rally by the Coordinating Committee on Manipur Integrity (COCOMI) in Imphal. The Naga organisations demanded termination of the agreement, accusing Kuki-Zo militant groups of being involved in violence.

The rallies came days after militants ambushed 14 Meitei men and killed three of them, sparking protests in the State.



Coming together: A rally organised by the Coordinating Committee on Manipur Integrity in Imphal on Saturday. AFP

Police put up barricades at Keisampat junction, just a few hundred metres from the Lok Bhavan, Chief Minister's Office and the BJP State office, and prevented the rally from moving ahead.

"We seek the resignation of the present government for its failure to protect the lives and properties of the indigenous people of the State," said COCOMI convenor Y. Dhiren.

A protester said, "After three-and-a-half years of crisis in Manipur, Naga tribes, Meiteis and the native people are coming together to raise their voice against the government for their policies"

For the first time since ethnic violence erupted in 2023, security forces have taken control of a camp meant to house Kuki-Zo militants under the nearly two-decade-old truce and plan to audit all 14 such camps across the State.

This rare takeover followed the discovery that only one of the 159 registered cadres was present at the camp, raising questions about compliance with the SoO agreement, which expired on September 4 without renewal. Under its rules, militants covered by it must remain in designated camps and keep their weapons under security arrangements.

ED detains SP leader two days after bail

Mayank Kumar
LUCKNOW

The Enforcement Directorate (ED) on Saturday detained Samajwadi Party leader Azam Khan from outside the Rampur jail in Uttar Pradesh immediately after he was released on bail in an alleged PAN fraud case, officials said.

Mr. Khan, 78, may soon be arrested under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA).

SP chief Akhilesh Yadav criticised the BJP for the action against Mr. Khan. "It is a very cowardly act to trap an elderly person in such frivolous cases and put him in jail again and again," he wrote on X.

Sudhir Panwar, a senior SP leader, said, that Mr. Khan's arrest smacked of political vendetta.

Modi says Opposition has become destructive force; calls for unity

Press Trust of India
EKTA NAGAR

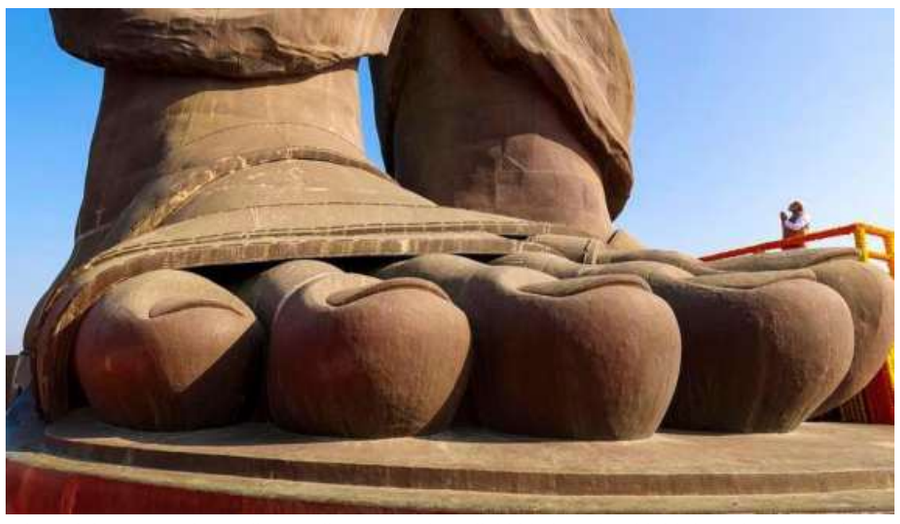
Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Saturday attacked the Opposition, saying it had turned into "*avrodh paksh* (obstructive side)" rather than "*virodh paksh* (opposing side)", and highlighted the need for the country to stay united.

He was addressing a gathering at the Parade Ground in Gujarat's Ekta Nagar on the occasion of Rashtriya Ekta Diwas, marking the 151st birth anniversary of Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel.

"It is our misfortune that the Opposition has turned into *avrodh paksh*," Mr. Modi said.

In a veiled reference to Congress leader Rahul Gandhi's foreign trips, the Prime Minister asked, "Who is secretly meeting whom in foreign countries? Forces opposed to India are extending their support to whom? Who is speaking the language of India's enemies?"

He said the nation needs to stand united against such forces and alleged that the Opposition wants to divide the people of the country.


Prime Minister Narendra Modi pays tribute to Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel on his birth anniversary at the Statue of Unity, in Ekta Nagar, Gujarat. PTI

'Dimagi Naxals'

"Social media is being used as a weapon, rumours are being spread, and India's image is being tarnished," he alleged.

"I said last year that we would not rest until the country was free from Naxalism and Maoism; that promise has been fulfilled. Though we have finished Naxals, the threat of '*dimagi* (intellectual) Naxals' remains very high," hesaid.

Mr. Modi told the gathering that India's next big steps include completely securing the country's borders, stopping infiltration and demographic changes, and moving towards a secular civil code.

New projects launched

Meanwhile, the Prime Minister inaugurated 23 development projects worth ₹307.83 crore to boost tourism and civic infrastructure at Ekta Nagar. He also laid the foundation stones for eight development projects worth ₹118.88 crore, taking the total outlay for the 31 projects to ₹426.71 crore.

Newly launched projects aim to upgrade visitor facilities and civic infrastructure around the world's tallest statue, which has developed into a major tourism hub.

Earlier in the day, Mr. Modi paid floral tributes to Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel at the Statue of Unity.

'Distorians' cannot erase the respect Indira had for Patel: Jairam Ramesh

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

Congress leader Jairam Ramesh on Saturday shared a rare photograph from 1947 featuring a young Indira Gandhi greeting Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel, who was then Deputy Prime Minister, and said "distorians" cannot erase the profound respect and admiration that Indira Gandhi had for the Congress stalwart.

"Two Indians, both indomitable and resolute. Both shaped subcontinental geography and history," he said on X.

'Architect of freedom'

"Today, we celebrate the 151st birth anniversary of a key architect of India's freedom and who made India's unity a living reality. He was also to inspire the White Revolution that came decades later," Mr. Ramesh said of Patel.

"Today, we also mark the 42nd death anniversary of a most courageous and consequential personality who made a free India strong as a nuclear and space power and catalysed the Green Revolution during her lifetime," he said of Indira Gandhi.


Mallikarjun Kharge, Sonia Gandhi and Rahul Gandhi pay tribute to Indira Gandhi at Shakti Sthal in New Delhi on Saturday. ANI

Sharing the picture, Mr. Ramesh said it was taken in early November 1947 in New Delhi, during a function hosted by the Prime Minister Jawaharlal Nehru for delegates to the Asian Regional Conference of the International Labour Organisation. The picture shows a 30-year-old Indira Gandhi greeting the 72-year-old Deputy Prime Minister, he said.

"Distorians cannot erase the profound respect and admiration that Indira Gandhi had for Sardar Patel, and she spoke from her heart on the occasion of his birth centenary. And Sardar Patel's was the only statue of a living person that Nehru himself unveiled in Godhra on February 13, 1949," he said.

Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge and former party chiefs Rahul Gandhi and Sonia Gandhi paid homage to her at the 'Indira Gandhi Memorial' at 1 Safdarjung Road, the residence of the former Prime Minister.

Rahul Gandhi shared a Sanskrit *shloka* she had taught him. "Sitting on your lap. Holding both your hands. Listening to your voice say these words. Repeating them after you. *Asato maa sadgamaya, tamaso maa jyotirgamaya, mrityor maa amritam gamaya* (Lead me from untruth to truth, from darkness to light, from death to immortality). *OM Shanti, Shanti, Shanti*. What a beautiful gift you gave me Dadi. What a gift. I never imagined."

'Unwavering resolve'

Mr. Kharge hailed Indira Gandhi as a symbol of indomitable courage, unwavering resolve and visionary leadership. "Her supreme sacrifice for the unity and integrity of our nation will forever be etched in our collective memory," Mr. Kharge said in a post on X in Hindi.

Congress general secretary Priyanka Gandhi Vadra also hailed her grandmother and former Prime Minister. "What a beautiful woman she was! Free as the sky, deep as the ocean, resilient as the earth and brighter than fire," she said.

Indira Gandhi was assassinated by her bodyguards in New Delhi on October 31, 1984.

Democratic institutions being ridiculed by INDIA bloc: BJP

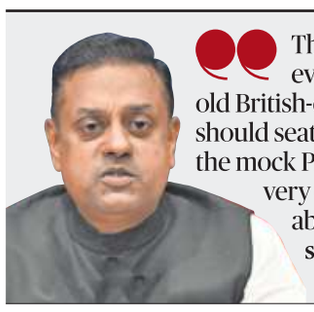
BJP MP Sambit Patra slams Opposition alliance over mock Parliament session; he says the parties have repeatedly disrupted the House during sessions; he also rejects allegations of 'vote theft'

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) on Saturday accused the Congress and its allies of ridiculing democratic institutions by staging a mock Parliament session, and said that Opposition parties had repeatedly disrupted proceedings in the real Parliament.

At a press conference, BJP MP Sambit Patra referred to the structure resembling the old Parliament building erected for the mock Parliament session and said: "They want to retain everything from the old British-era structure... They should seat Rahul Gandhi *ji* as the mock Prime Minister in that very old structure. We have absolutely no objection."

He was referring to the Indian National Developmental, Inclusive Alliance's (INDIA bloc) mock Parliament session held at Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge's New Delhi residence on Saturday for a symbolic "public impeachment" of Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar over allegations of irregularities in the special intensive revision (SIR) of electoral rolls and the conduct of elections.



> They want to retain everything from the old British-era structure... They should seat Rahul Gandhi *ji* as the mock Prime Minister in that very old structure. We have absolutely no objection
>
> **SAMBIT PATRA**
> BJP national spokesperson

SIR exercise

Responding to the Opposition's "vote *chori*" charge, Mr. Patra said: "If your 38 lakh BLAs (booth-level agents) had been doing their work properly, you would not have needed to hold this mock Parliament today."

On the allegation that voting rights of 13 crore people were "stolen", he said if that had been the case, the affected people would have taken to the streets. "The reality is that not a single person's vote has been stolen," he said. He pointed out that SIR had been conducted 10 times during Congress rule and accused the party of double standards. Explaining the figure, Mr. Patra claimed that about 12 crore voters had permanently shifted, and of them, about 6 crore had already filled in Form 6 to be included in the voter list. Notices had been sent to the remaining individuals and the process was underway, he said, adding that those marked absent were also being included. About 2.8 crore names were deleted on account of their death and nearly 1 crore duplicate entries were also removed, he said.

Rejecting the charge that Form 6 had been amended, he said only a declaration was added and that the Supreme Court judgment dated May 27, 2026, addressed the matter clearly. He also said the Election Commission of India (ECI) had clarified that decisions on SIR were taken unanimously.

Constitutional norms

The BJP leader refuted the accusation that the BJP brought in a 2023 law to grant immunity to Election Commissioners (EC), arguing that constitutional protection already existed and the law only laid down the procedure. He cited a Telangana lower court order in July 2023 for the registration of a case against the Chief Election Commissioner and others. The directive was set aside by the High Court.

"However, at that time, it was felt that due to political pressure, even constitutional authorities who enjoy protection under the Constitution could be subjected to cases without any consideration," he said.

Earlier, BJP MP Sudhanshu Trivedi said the World Bank's 2025 report acknowledged India's success in reducing poverty under the leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi. According to the report, between 2011 and 2023, extreme poverty declined from 27.6% to just 2.6%.

At 'public impeachment', voters question deletion of names from electoral rolls

Sandeep Phukan
NEW DELHI

The Indian National Developmental, Inclusive Alliance's (INDIA) symbolic "public impeachment" of Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar on Saturday featured accounts from voters who alleged that their names had been deleted from electoral rolls during the special intensive revision (SIR) exercise.

Among them was Anita Jaiswal, who moved from Kolkata to Delhi. She said she had voted in every election between 2012 and 2025 but was now being asked to establish her citizenship.

"I am a single mother. They told me to get an Aadhaar card, saying it would prove that I am a citizen. Who gave you the right to remove my voter ID? My daughter gets a scholarship, has a bank account and an Aadhaar card, and now you are deleting our names. Who gave you the right?" she said.

Iftikar Ahmed, another voter from Kolkata, said he had voted in the same Chowrangee constituency for 20 years but received a notice during the SIR hearing seeking documents because of a mapping discrepancy. His father, too, had been voting from the same address for two decades, he said. "Our names have been removed in a planned manner," he alleged.



RTI activist cites ECI response stating that no files recording the decision-making process behind the SIR exists. PTI

Nikhil Dey, founder of Mazdoor Kisan Shakti Sangathan, who has been working with affected voters, introduced Kanta Prasad, who had been declared dead in the exercise. "He spoke very convincingly for a corpse! The deprivation of the right to vote is a crime against the Constitution and a blot on our democracy. There must be accountability," Congress MP Shashi Tharoor said in a post on X.

RTI activist Anjali Bharadwaj said that in response to an application seeking copies of files recording the decision-making process behind the SIR, the Election Commission of India (ECI) had replied that no such file existed. "T. C. Kom, who is a Principal Secretary, said the ECI had not taken any decision to conduct an SIR," Ms. Bharadwaj claimed.

All India Students' Association (AISA) national president Neha Bora alleged that the SIR was a attempt to disenfranchise young voters and undermine democracy. Neha said their statutory authority was being overridden through the use of software to exclude eligible voters.

Congress calls BJP campaign on democracy 'hypocrisy'

The Hindu Bureau
CHANDIGARH

The Haryana Congress on Saturday described the Bharatiya Janata Party's (BJP) decision to launch a campaign "*Loktantra Bachao, Arajakta Hatao*" (Save Democracy, Eliminate Anarchy) as the height of political hypocrisy and a desperate attempt to divert the country's attention from uncomfortable questions concerning electoral transparency.

Haryana Congress incharge Sanjay Dutt said the BJP has systematically weakened democratic institutions and now preaching the virtues of democracy.

"The party that wants an Election Commission subservient to its interests is now lecturing the Opposition on democratic values. The party that has no answers to the serious allegations of vote theft is branding those demanding answers as anarchists," he said in a statement.

BJP national president Nitin Nabin will lead a *padyatra* in Rohtak on November 1 as part of the party's nationwide campaign, against what the BJP describes as the Opposition's misinformation propaganda.

Punjab govt. to set up 35 special NDPS courts

Press Trust of India
CHANDIGARH

The Punjab Cabinet on Saturday approved setting up of 35 exclusive special National Drugs and Psychotropic Substances (NDPS) courts across the State to ensure speedy disposal of drug-related cases, reduce judicial pendency and strengthen the ongoing fight against the drug menace.

A statement from the Chief Minister's Office said that Punjab is facing a serious challenge of drug trafficking and abuse, with approximately 20,000 NDPS cases registered and around 27,000 arrests made annually. Of these, approximately 12,000 cases are tried by sessions courts, while only around 5,700 are disposed of annually, resulting in 52,577 pending cases as on August 31, 2026. Consequently, the average disposal time for such cases is approximately eight years, it said.

AAP releases first list of 40 candidates for 2027 Punjab polls

The Hindu Bureau
CHANDIGARH

Taking the lead in announcing candidates for the Punjab Assembly election, due in early 2027, the ruling Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) on Saturday released its list of 40 candidates, all of them sitting legislators.

Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann will re-contest from the Dhuri Assembly constituency in Sangrur district.

There are 117 Assembly seats in Punjab and the five-year term of the Assembly ends on March 16, 2027. The AAP registered a landslide victory in the 2022 Assembly election by winning 92 seats.

Among prominent candidates, the Punjab Assembly Speaker Kultar Singh Sandhwan will contest from Kotkapura, while Minister Sanjeev Arora, currently in jail in an alleged money laundering case, is the party's candidate from Ludhiana West. Others include Kuldeep Singh Dhaliwal from Ajnala, Inderbir Singh Nijjar from Amritsar South, Kulwant Singh from SAS Nagar, and Bram Shanker Sharma Jimpa from Hoshiarpur constituency.



Bhagwant Mann

"Our party's principle is that, three or four months before Assembly elections are held, we release the list of candidates. Candidates will get the opportunity to go to the people and take the government's work to them," Mr. Mann said.

U.P. deactivates ECINET logins for EROs' computer assistants over Pilibhit voter roll 'rigging'

Sreeparna Chakrabarty
NEW DELHI

Opposition parties alleged that details of 13,150 voters were altered on the rolls in Pilibhit Sadar seat

The Chief Electoral Officer (CEO) of Uttar Pradesh on Saturday directed the immediate deactivation of the login IDs of all computer assistants working on the ECINET Portal in the offices of Electoral Registration Officers (EROs) across the State.

The action comes in response to complaints and information from Pilibhit district regarding the misuse of login IDs provided to computer assistants, who work as voter registration centre operators, on the ECINET portal, the State CEO's office said in a statement.

Opposition parties, including the Congress, had alleged that the details of 13,150 registered voters were altered on the rolls in the Pilibhit Sadar Assembly seat, even though their Elector Photo Identity Card (EPIC) numbers and serial numbers remained exactly the same. Subsequently, in the 347-Azamgarh constituency, 13 entries bearing the name Vikas Yadav appeared in the electoral rolls.

On October 25, the Uttar Pradesh CEO had ordered the re-verification of all entries made by computer assistants since the publication of the final electoral rolls, after the special intensive revision (SIR) exercise, on April 10.

On Saturday, CEO Navdeep Rinwa asked EROs to submit a compliance report on the deactivation of login IDs at the earliest, and directed the immediate termination of services of the computer assistant involved in the Pilibhit case. "The concerned firm has been directed to immediately terminate the service of the involved outsourced computer assistant in the case of Assembly Constituency 127-Pilibhit," the statement said. There are around 806 computer operators deployed in ERO offices across U.P.

Each Assembly constituency has two computer assistants working as operators at voter registration centres in ERO offices.

Gorakhpur-registered KND Engineers and Consultants (India) Private Limited is currently the company to which the hiring of computer operators is outsourced, but sources told *The Hindu* that while the companies keep changing change every year after a tender process, the employees are drawn from the same list available on the government portal, and most have been working as operators for eight to 10 years.

Why appeal against voter inclusion, asks Bengal's Opposition

Shiv Sahay Singh
KOLKATA

Opposition parties in West Bengal have stepped up the heat on the issue of 16.10 lakh appeals filed against the inclusion of voters following the special intensive revision (SIR) in the State.

Leaders of the Mamata All India Trinamool Congress and the Communist Party of India (Marxist) have questioned the lack of clarity over who authorised the filing of the appeals after the SIR concluded in the State.

Communist Party of India (Marxist) West Bengal State secretary Mohammad Salim described the development as a "ghostly affair", with officials shifting responsibility.

"Everyone is busy dodging responsibility. Is it some ghostly affair? The responsibility of disenfranchising lakhs upon lakhs of citizens must surely fall on #CEC and #CEO for washing their hands clean," Mr. Salim said.

The CPI(M) leader was referring to a recent statement by Subrata Gupta, former special observer for the West Bengal SIR exercise, who reportedly said that he had "no information" about the CEO office filing lakhs of appeals seeking to remove voters whose names had been cleared by judicial officers.

The Mamata AITC leadership also questioned the role of the ECI in filing lakhs of appeals seeking to remove voters whose names had been cleared. "Subrata Gupta (now advisor to CM Suvendu Adhikari) - during West Bengal's SIR has told *The Wire* that he had no information about the Chief Electoral Officer's office filing lakhs of appeals seeking to remove voters whose names had been cleared by judicial officers," the party said on social media.

17 NC MLAs meet, send demands to Farooq; no confrontation, says party

Peerzada Ashiq
SRINAGAR

Disgruntled National Conference (NC) legislators on Saturday forwarded a list of demands to party president Farooq Abdullah, even as the party provincial president, Showkat Ahmad Mir, downplayed the Friday meeting organised by 17 legislators.

"A meeting of NC MLAs was an internal exercise in democracy. It discussed concerns and future challenges. No one had spoken against the party organisation or the government. There was no confrontation with the leadership. There is no rebellion. Even in families, there are occasions when family members get upset," said Mr. Mir.



Showkat Ahmad Mir

On legislators' public display of disappointment, Mr. Mir said, "Everyone wants to become a Minister. There are expectations, particularly from those who have won elections repeatedly. But Mr. Abdullah has only eight ministerial positions available (in the Union Territory), which is why he initially inducted five Ministers. If Statehood is restored, more ministerial berths could be filled."

His statement came a day after a meeting of disgruntled 17 NC legislators was held at a legislator's residence in Srinagar over the recent Cabinet expansion "without consultation".

Distribution of portfolios "despite certain objections" and the role of Chief Minister's adviser Nasir Aslam Wani and MP Shami Oberoi were also discussed. Meanwhile, the party sources said a list of demands by the disgruntled legislators was forwarded to the party president Dr. Farooq Abdullah. It demanded "intensifying" the struggle for restoration of Statehood, implementation of the promises made in the 2024 manifesto to within six months, removing Mr. Wani, and reconsidering portfolios assigned to Deputy Chief Minister Surinder Choudhary.

Several senior NC legislators had been upset after they did not get any ministerial berths and the party's move to retain four ministers from the previous Cabinet. They also demanded a democratic mechanism within the party to discuss proposed names for the Cabinet before the final decision.

RSS leader says protests should be guided by national interest

Ishita Mishra
NEW DELHI

Everyone has the right to raise issues concerning the country through demonstrations, but such protests must be conducted with the national interest in mind, Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS) national publicity in-charge Sunil Ambekar said on Saturday.

He also urged people to remain vigilant against attempts by anti-national forces to exploit public demonstrations.

Mr. Ambekar was speaking to the media in Indore ahead of the RSS's three-day national meeting, scheduled to begin on Monday. The meeting is expected to bring together 408 senior functionaries, including RSS chief Mohan Bhagwat and general secretary Dattatreya Hosabale.



Sunil Ambekar

Discussions are likely to cover organisational changes within the Sangh ahead of its election year, centenary-year programmes, and other issues.

Asked whether the Sangh had been slow to connect with the younger generations, particularly in the wake of the recent Gen Z protests at Delhi's Jantar Mantar, Mr. Ambekar said people are free to raise questions or concerns about issues affecting the country. He added that the RSS should not be seen as taking sides on matters raised by citizens. "If someone raises a question concerning the country, that is fine. They have the right to do so," he said.

Referring to the RSS chief's Vijayadasami address in which he had spoken about the need to guard against agitations that could divide society, Mr. Ambekar said protests should serve the country's interests and contribute to its progress.

Hardeep Puri files papers for M.P. Rajya Sabha bypoll

Press Trust of India
BHOPAL

Union Petroleum Minister Hardeep Singh Puri, the BJP's nominee for the November 12 Rajya Sabha byelection in Madhya Pradesh, filed his nomination papers on Saturday.

The papers were filed in the presence of Chief Minister Mohan Yadav and BJP state president Hemant Khandelwal.

The BJP has fielded Mr. Puri from the seat vacated by L. Murugan, who resigned from the Union Government and the Upper House earlier this month. Mr. Murugan's Rajya Sabha term was due to end in April 2030.

INBRIEF



ACM Ashutosh Dixit takes charge as 29th IAF chief

Air Chief Marshal Ashutosh Dixit, a seasoned fighter pilot with over 3,500 hours of flying experience on more than 20 types of aircraft, on Saturday assumed charge as the 29th Chief of the Air Staff, succeeding Air Chief Marshal A.P. Singh, who retired after a distinguished career spanning 43 years. The Indian Air Force (IAF) accorded a ceremonial guard of honour to Air Chief Marshal Singh at the Race Course Air Force Station here before he handed over the baton to his successor. Air Chief Marshal Dixit, who was serving as the Vice Chief of the Air Staff, played a key role in strategic planning during Operation Sindoor.

Omar Abdullah marries journalist Nidhi Razdan

Jammu and Kashmir Chief Minister Omar Abdullah, 56, on Saturday announced his marriage with journalist Nidhi Razdan, a day after a lowkey ceremony held in New Delhi. Posting the wedding pictures on *X*, Mr. Abdullah said, "A new journey began yesterday." Ms. Razdan also posted pictures with a joyful message, "It's done bro". The announcement evoked a barrage of congratulatory messages from netizens, friends and party workers. The second marriage of Mr. Abdullah came three months after a legal battle over his divorce which ended in "a mutual consent settlement" in the Supreme Court of India on July 31.

490 policemen awarded Grihmantri Dakshata Padak

Four hundred and ninety personnel from various States, Union Territories, Central Armed Police Forces (CAPFs) and Central Police Organisations (CPOs) were awarded the Kendriya Grihmantri Dakshata Padak on Saturday, the birth anniversary of Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel, a government statement said. The list also includes 14 officers from the CBI. The award was instituted through a Ministry of Home Affairs notification dated February 1, 2024. It is conferred on members of police forces, security organisations, intelligence wings, special branches of States and Union Territories, CAPFs, CPOs, the National Security Guard and Assam Rifles, it said. PTI

IIT-ISM Dhanbad student dies after falling from 8th floor

A final-year student at the Indian Institute of Technology (Indian School of Mines), Dhanbad, died after falling from the eighth floor of a campus hostel on Saturday. According to the police, the incident occurred around 8 a.m. The student has been identified as 21-year-old Mane Rajkumar Pratik from Ahmedpur city in Latur district, Maharashtra. "As soon as we got the information, we rushed to the spot and took him to the nearest Asarfi Hospital. However, the doctors' attempts to revive him failed," IIT-ISM chief security officer Ram Manohar told *The Hindu*.

(Those in distress can contact Tele MANAS at 14416 to seek help)

SUDOKU

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2					1	4		
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DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★☆☆

Solution to yesterday's Sudoku

7	2	3	9	8	6	1	5	4
5	4	6	1	3	7	9	8	2
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8	7	1	4	2	9	3	6	5
4	3	2	6	7	5	8	9	1
2	8	4	7	9	1	5	3	6
3	6	9	2	5	4	7	1	8
1	5	7	3	6	8	4	2	9

108 stupas in Bhutan will have India-linked Buddha relics

Rahul Karmakar
GELEPHU

Buddhist relics of Indian origin will be enshrined in most of the 108 *jangchub chortens* (stupas of enlightenment) that monks and volunteers are scheduled to build simultaneously along a 12 km stretch of the Mau Chhu River in the Bhutanese town of Gelephu on Sunday.

The event will mark the spiritual foundation of the Gelephu Mindfulness City (GMC), which Bhutan's King Jigme Khesar Namgyel Wangchuk envisions as a spirituality-driven global economic hub. About 240 km south-southeast of Bhutan's capital, Thimphu, the city borders Assam's Chirang district.

The Central Monastic Body of Bhutan, the country's principal institutional carrier of the Drukpa Kagyu lineage of Tibetan Buddhism, said that Buddhists in Malaysia, Singapore, Taiwan, Thailand, and Bhutan had donated hundreds of relics, mostly bones and hair.

"Malaysia sent three sets of 108 relics of the Buddha, enlightened saints and revered lamas. We received many from Thailand. Most of the relics were established as having been sourced from India," Choten Dorji, the Principal Secretary to one of the masters of the monastic body, said on Saturday.

The relics form part of the '*zung*', the living embodiment of the Buddha's enlightened body, speech and mind. The sacred components of the *zung* include *thangkhas* (traditional Tibetan Buddhist paintings on cotton or silk fabric), statues, precious stones, rolled mantra scrolls, or *dharanis*, and relics of enlightened beings.



All set: The podium set up for the Bhutan King's address during the ceremony. RAHUL KARMAKAR

The *jangchub chorten* commemorates the Buddha's attainment of enlightenment and symbolises the triumph of wisdom over ignorance. Once consecrated, a *chorten* is rendered equivalent to the living Buddha.

On February 26, King Wangchuk announced Project 108 at the GMC as a "test of national character", not merely an initiative to set a world record.

"It is an ambitious undertaking that demands courage, unity, and deep commitment. We must do it to prove to ourselves that, as we face the challenges ahead, there is no limit to what we can achieve when we stand together," he said.

Officials said that Project 108, involving 40,000 trained volunteers, was Bhutan's sacred gesture of peace in a world troubled by conflict.

Each *chorten* is estimated to cost $200,000, and individuals, families, communities, and institutions worldwide have contributed to the project.

According to the blueprint, each *chorten* will stand 15 metres tall, positioned 108 metres apart in a line along the Mau Chhu River, which runs through Gelephu.

Significance of '108'

Bhutan's spiritual leaders explained the rationale behind the number 108.

"In astronomy, the distance between the earth and the sun is approximately 108 times the sun's diameter and the distance between the earth and the moon is about 108 times the moon's diameter," a monk said.

"In some Tibetan Buddhist traditions, the Kangyur (principal collection of sacred Buddhist scriptures) is arranged in 108 volumes. Practitioners count 108 beads on a prayer mala, circumambulate sacred sites 108 times, and ring temple bells 108 times. In the Vajrayana Buddhist tradition, 108 symbolises spiritual completeness, cosmic balance, and the purification of karma," he said.

Project 108 also links to Hinduism. "Hindu tradition often speaks of 108 Upanishads (sacred philosophical texts). Many Hindu deities have 108 names. In yoga, the sun salutation is traditionally performed in cycles of 108," the monk said.

The date for executing Project 108 is significant, too. Bhutan observes November 1 as Lord Buddha's Descending Day and Mother's Day. Sunday also marks the 18th coronation anniversary of King Wangchuk, who reached Gelephu with his royal entourage on Saturday.

Hundreds march in Kolkata against attacks on bookstalls

Citizens, activists, professors, politicians join the march, 'Walk for Books', which was held without any political banner; it was organised in protest against attacks on bookstalls during Durga Puja

Shrabana Chatterjee
KOLKATA

Hundreds of people walked holding books in their hands at a rally in Kolkata on Saturday protesting against recent attacks on books and bookstalls, blamed on right-wing groups and the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP). The march, "Walk for Books", was conducted without any political banners, with common citizens, activists, professors, and politicians taking part in it.



Pages of history: People during the 'Walk for Books' (*Boiyer Jonno Hatun*) rally in Kolkata on Saturday. PTI

The march was organised on College Street, popularly known as *Boipara* (books neighbourhood) of Kolkata, as hundreds walked holding books, banners, and posters. "*Boi amader bondhu, boi-er jonno hathun*" (Books are our friends, walk for books), read one of the banners.

Senior Communist Party of India (Marxist) leaders, including State secretary Mohammad Salim, Sujan Chakraborty, Biman Bose, and others, showed up at the protest.

CPI(M) leader Shatarup Ghosh, who took part in the march, said that such a protest was unheard of in Kolkata, because such an attack on books was also unheard of. "The type of attack will determine the type of protest. Many who are walking in this march have no relation to the Left ideologies, but they have shown up for the love of books," Mr. Ghosh said.

Many sang, recited poems, played musical instruments, raised slogans, and held their copy of books high above their heads or close to their chests as they marched on.

"It was heartfelt to see such an organic march for books; I have never seen such a thing before. People from ages 8-80 were all walking together. As a book lover and publisher, it is my responsibility to walk in this march," Subrata Das, a publisher and owner of Setu Publication, told *The Hindu*.

"Education is one of the most important things in the contemporary world, but this attack on books by the current government is pathetic. They want to crack down on education and books so that people do not learn and do not ask questions," a research scholar from Jadavpur University, who took part in the march, said on the condition of anonymity.

A call for the march was written and signed by several prominent personalities in the State such as academician Pabitra Sarkar, former MP Jawhar Sircar, journalist Paranjoy Guha Thakurta, actor Sabyasachi Chakraborty, playwright Chandan Sen, and many others.

Vandalism reported

During the Durga Puja festivities last month, repeated attacks were reported on Left parties' book stalls in West Bengal. According to senior CPI(M) leader Sujan Chakraborty, at least 292 stalls were vandalised. However, the attacks worked in their favour, as common people and politicians alike showed up at their stalls in solidarity in large numbers and drove up sales beyond ₹1.5 crore.

Several right-wing groups and BJP workers are blamed for these attacks. However, the BJP has denied these allegations and condemned the attacks even as Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari continued his verbal attack on the book stalls.

ISRO flew NVS-03 satellite with pyro valves open: chief

Press Trust of India
SRIHARIKOTA

ISRO chief V. Narayanan on Saturday said that in order to ensure mission reliability and bypass previous technical hurdles, the NVS-03 satellite was operated with "three pyro valves open".

Addressing the media at a post-launch press conference, Mr. Narayanan revealed that this bold technical decision was validated after rigorous vibration and shock testing by a national-level committee chaired by former ISRO chief Kiran Kumar.

Pyro valves are crucial in spacecraft propulsion, and it may be recalled that the NVS-02 (launched in 2025), the second spacecraft in the NVS series, was a failure.

A high-level panel, after thorough analysis, concluded that "the drive signal did not reach the pyro valve of the oxidiser line of the engine meant for orbit raising."

In February 2026, ISRO announced that the most likely cause was the disengagement of at least one contact (in each of the main and redundant paths) of the connector.

Against this background, Mr. Narayanan said that with four satellites, including NVS-01 now active in India's navigation satellite system, ISRO plans to launch NVS-04 in five months, and NVS-05 in 10 months to further bolster the constellation.

'Exceptional accuracy'

Mr. Narayanan highlighted the exceptional accuracy of the flight. "Against [the planned] perigee [the point in an orbit closest to Earth] of 170.36 km, we have got 170.31 kilometres," he said.

"Against [the planned] apogee [the point in an orbit farthest from Earth] of 37,247 kilometres, we achieved 38,080 kilometres," he noted. "This is one of the best accuracy of any of the launch vehicles in the world we can think of," he added.

The successful deployment has restored India's NavIC (Navigation with Indian Constellation) to its minimum operating configuration of four satellites, bolstering both strategic and civilian location services across the subcontinent.

The ISRO successfully placed NVS-03 into a highly precise orbit using the GSLV-F18 launch vehicle on Saturday.

CPCB threatens to shut NCR firms yet to order pollution-control tools

Jacob Koshy
NEW DELHI

The Central Pollution Control Board (CPCB) has directed pollution control authorities in Delhi-NCR to shut industrial units that have failed to place orders for installing or upgrading air pollution control devices (APCDs). Though not a new measure, it signals a tightening of enforcement of emission standards ahead of the winter pollution season.

In an October 30 letter, the CPCB has asked the Delhi Pollution Control Committee (DPCC) and the State Pollution Control Boards of Haryana, Uttar Pradesh, and Rajasthan to immediately issue show-cause notices to non-compliant units covered under the Commission for Air Quality Management's (CAQM) revised emission norms. Units that fail to produce evidence of having placed orders for the equipment within five days are to face closure orders and remain shut until they demonstrate compliance with a credible installation timeline, the letter notes.

The direction comes ahead of restrictions scheduled to take effect in Delhi from November 1 under the government's winter pollution management framework, which includes curbs on vehicles, construction activities and other pollution sources. After peaking in the "poor" category around 222-232 mid-week (October 28-29), continuous rainfall dropped Delhi's average AQI to 60 on Friday and around 95 on Saturday morning, according to the Indian Institute of Tropical Meteorology-maintained network.

India's first fusion power company sets road map for a nuclear reactor

Jacob Koshy
NEW DELHI

If all goes to plan, India may see designs for the first privately-built tokamak, a nuclear reactor that uses fusion to produce energy, firmed up in 2027.

Bengaluru-based startup Pranos Fusion has built PRAGYA, a small doughnut-shaped tokamak, to test plasma control and superconducting magnets. This is a gateway to building PRANIK, a larger tokomak that will have plasma heated up to millions of degrees – more than the interior of the Sun – necessary to fuse hydrogen atoms and create energy.

"By 2027, we expect to finalise the blueprint for PRANIK and be on our way to building a practical reactor that can produce energy. To be able to actually produce electricity from fusion is a further step away," Shaurya Kaushal, co-founder and CEO of Pranos Fusion, said.



Fusion frontier: The Bengaluru-based startup has built a compact tokamak as a test bed for plasma control. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Nuclear plants everywhere employ fission – a chain reaction involving uranium nuclei to produce heat that is used to generate electricity. Fusion, on the other hand, releases energy when light atomic nuclei merge, and usually involves joining two forms of hydrogen – deuterium and tritium – into helium and a fast neutron. However, this requires the fuel to be heated to around 100 million degrees Celsius, far hotter than any solid wall could withstand. In tokamaks, powerful magnets hold this superheated plasma away from the walls, keeping it hot enough for fusion to continue.

"Electricity from a fusion reactor is still far away and would be expensive now, however the need for any source of energy is only going to grow," co-founder Roshan George said.

"Fusion's advantage is that while [it's] nuclear power, it doesn't need radioactive material like uranium. India already produces plenty of deuterium. Fusion reactions are also not chain reactions, and therefore the risk of a runaway reaction [like in a fission reactor] is almost absent," Mr. George added.

The cost of a private tokamak depends on scale, Mr. Kaushal said. A compact research machine like PRAGYA is "a comparatively modest investment".

Pranos Fusion says compact machines, HTS (high-temperature superconducting) magnets, and India's manufacturing base can bring costs down substantially. It is backed by Ankur Capital, pi Ventures and Industrial47, and has raised $7.2 million.



Pretty blossoms: Farmers harvest cockscomb flowers on the outskirts of Srinagar.



A blooming affair: A butterfly feeds on nectar from a cockscomb flower.



Nature's pigment: Cockscomb flowers are harvested at full bloom for their red pigment.



Preparations under way: Bashir Ahmad, a farmer, arranges freshly harvested cockscomb flowers inside his house in Srinagar for drying.

Velvety crimson is Kashmir's treasure

Deeply rooted in Kashmir's culinary heritage, the cockscomb flower lends a rich red hue to traditional cuisine; the petals, which are sun-dried and preserved for year-round use, serve as an indispensable ingredient in *wazwan*



Imran Nissar
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The cockscomb flower (*Celosia cristata*) is recognisable by its distinctive, velvety, fan-shaped crest that resembles a rooster's comb. Rich crimson pigment is concentrated in the dense and highly textured folds of the blossom and these petals are harvested and dried to give traditional Kashmiri dishes their signature ruby-red colour.

Cultivated in the fertile valleys of Kashmir, these blossoms are carefully handpicked at peak bloom, sun-dried to preserve their intense natural pigments, and stored for year-round culinary use. The dried flowers are locally known as *mawal*.

Mawal holds a sacred status in the *wazwan* – the famous multi-course royal feast prepared by master chefs known as *wazas*. It imparts a subtle, earthy undertone that seamlessly complements heavy spices without overpowering them. *Mawal* is usually sold in the traditional markets of Srinagar. To release the signature crimson colour, the dried flower petals or *mawal* powder is steeped in hot water. The resulting rich, ruby extract is then strained directly into simmering gravies.

Mawal is indispensable in classics like rogan josh (meat curry), adding colour and flavour to the famed gravy alongside mild Kashmiri red chillies. It is also added to dishes like *rista* (spiced meatball curry), *mirchi korma* (chillies curry), and vegetarian specialities like *dum aloo* (potato curry).

Mawal reflects Kashmir's deep-rooted heritage of using local flora for natural, organic cooking. In traditional medicine, it is valued for its soothing and cooling properties, making rich, meat-heavy *wazwan* courses easier to digest.

As an irreplaceable element of Kashmir's gastronomic identity, *mawal* helps elevate every feast into a visually stunning and authentic experience.

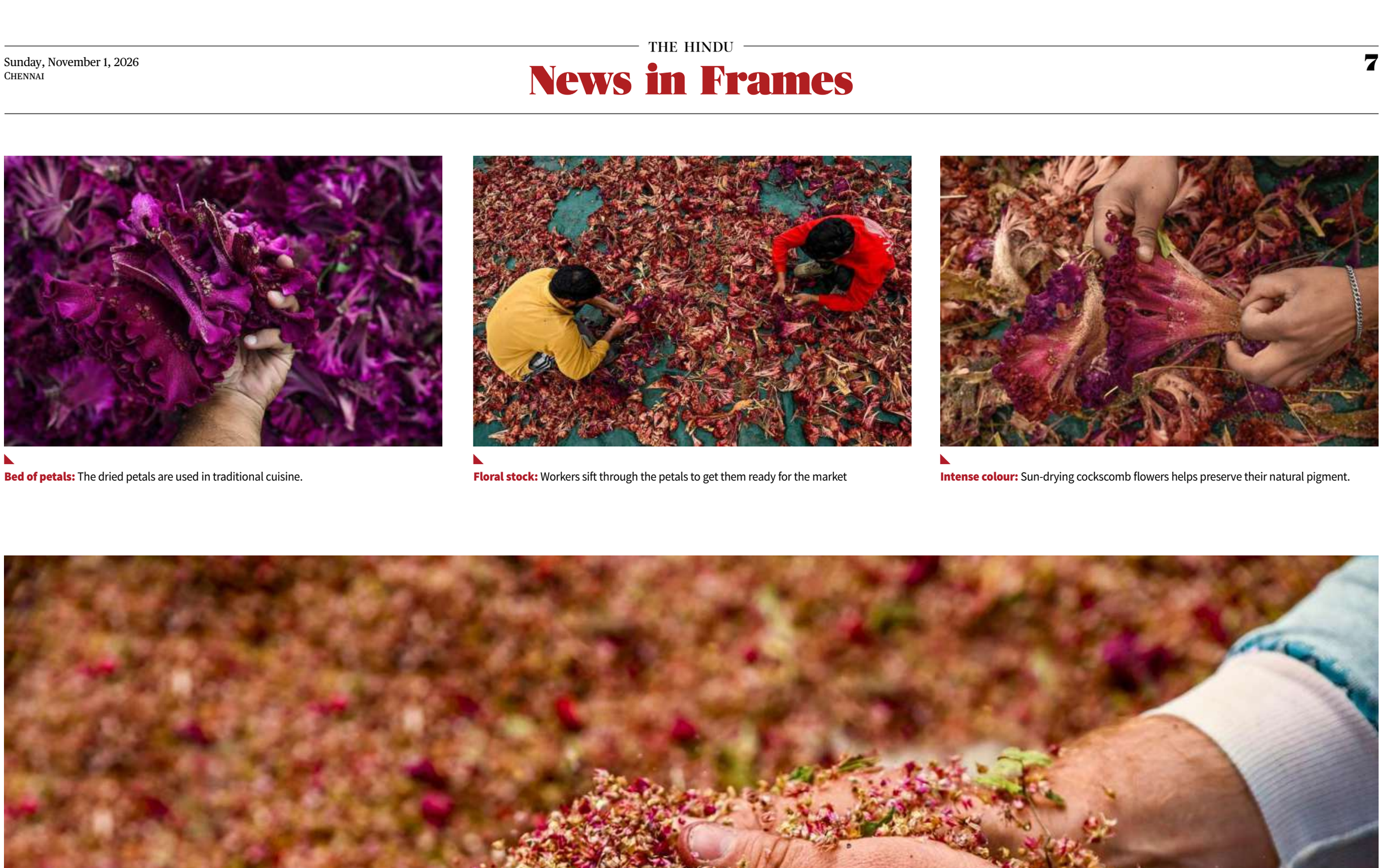


Slick cut: Flowers being harvested for their petals. Once dehydrated, the red blooms are stored and later ground into a powder or used to extract the natural colouring for Kashmiri dishes.

Bed of petals: The dried petals are used in traditional cuisine.

Floral stock: Workers sift through the petals to get them ready for the market

Intense colour: Sun-drying cockscomb flowers helps preserve their natural pigment.



Finishing touch: A farmer shows the dry petals, which become a prized ingredient for rich gravies and sumptuous dishes.



Before the feast: A chef presses the essence of powdered cockscomb flower into a dish for *wazwan*, Kashmir's traditional multi-course banquet.



Colouring tradition: Powdered *mawal* is ready to offer a rich colour to traditional cuisine.



Vibrant hues: A *waza*, a traditional Kashmiri master chef, adds the essence of *mawal* to a dish during the preparation of *wazwan*. The flower lends its distinctive crimson hue to dishes such as *rogan josh* and *rista*.

What do the new E100 vehicle rules mean?

What has changed? Should existing vehicles switch to E85 or E100? What are the concerns over ethanol blending?

Jagriti Chandra

The story so far:

The Ministry of Road Transport and Highways has amended the Central Motor Vehicles Rules, 1989, to permit the use of ethanol-based fuels containing up to 100% ethanol (E100) in vehicles. The move paves the way for flex-fuel (flexible fuel) vehicles, which can run on petrol, ethanol blends of varying proportions, or pure ethanol.

While petrol is refined from crude oil extracted from the earth, ethanol is a type of alcohol that can be produced by fermenting plant biomass (such as sugarcane, maize, or broken rice). The two fuels can be mixed.

What has the government changed?

One of the key changes is the inclusion of E100, or fuel comprising 100% ethanol, alongside E85 in several tables under Rule 115, which deals with emission standards and related requirements for motor vehicles. E85 is a fuel containing up to 85% ethanol, while E100 consists entirely of ethanol, subject to applicable fuel specifications. The amendments include an explanatory note stating that E85 or E100 may be used only in flex-fuel vehicles designed by original equipment manufacturers.

Should existing vehicles switch to E85 or E100?

No. In a press statement, the Ministry clarified that a vehicle's compatibility with E10 or E20 does not establish its suitability for E85. The notification does not require owners of existing vehicles to switch to E85 or modify their vehicles, either now or later. Motorists should check the fuel-compatibility sticker on their vehicle and follow the manufacturer's guidance in the owner's manual when choosing fuel at a filling station, the Ministry's statement added.

The notification does not require owners of existing vehicles to switch to E85 or modify their vehicles, either now or later

How will the amendments support the roll-out of E100 vehicles?

The amendments are expected to facilitate homologation, the official certification process through which authorised agencies, such as the Automotive Research Association of India, verify that vehicles and components comply with technical, safety, and environmental standards before they can be approved for sale or use on public roads. This will help secure type approvals for E100-powered vehicles, supporting their roll-out and wider consumer adoption. Corrections have also been incorporated into fuel classifications, including a reference to gasoline blended with 20% ethanol, or E20, in place of an earlier notation referring to E10.

What is the status of the Ethanol Blended Petrol Programme now?

India achieved its 20% ethanol-blending (E20) target in 2025, five years ahead of the original 2030 deadline set under the National Policy on Biofuels, 2018. From April 2026, all Bharat Stage-VI (BS-VI) vehicles are required to fully meet E20 emission standards, and all petrol sold across India is mandated to contain 20% ethanol (E20). The policy focus is now widening beyond E20: the government has enabled the regulatory pathway for E85 and E100 vehicles, though these will require compatible flex-fuel vehicles and dedicated dispensing infrastructure.

What are consumers' concerns?

The main concern is vehicle compatibility. Owners of older or non-E20-compliant vehicles question whether E20 could damage components, raise maintenance costs, or leave them without access to lower-ethanol petrol.

Consumers also question E20's effect on fuel economy. Ethanol has a lower energy density than petrol; while the government estimates a 5% decline in mileage, some consumers say the loss is greater. Dealers, meanwhile, warn that ethanol's affinity for water could raise contamination risks during the monsoon, strengthening the case for separate storage and dispensing systems for higher blends.

Users have also questioned why blending of ethanol has not reduced retail fuel prices. The government has responded by saying that procurement of raw materials such as maize at ₹71.86 per litre is higher than $70 per barrel of crude oil (or ₹37 to ₹40 per litre).

Experts argue that the focus on ethanol blending risks distracting from electrification, which they say offers a clearer long-term path to deep emissions cuts. "The future is electric. Other technologies are interim solutions. Electrification is cleaner, avoids the lifecycle emissions associated with ethanol production, and offers public health and climate benefits," said Amit Bhatt, managing director, International Council on Clean Transportation.

There are also concerns about the land and water required for large-scale ethanol production, the choice of crops used as feedstock, and the potential competition between fuel and food production.

Why are social media takedowns in focus?

What triggered the latest wave of takedowns? How do the amended IT rules make takedowns faster? Are takedowns being driven by government orders? What can users do when their accounts get blocked?

Lavpreet Kaur

The story so far:

In recent weeks, social media users have reported a spate of posts, reels, and accounts being blocked or taken down across platforms, including Instagram, Facebook, and X. Screenshots shared online show notices stating, 'Your post is unavailable in India', while others say access to content has been restricted through an automated system implemented under India's Information Technology or IT (Intermediary Guidelines and Digital Media Ethics Code) Rules, 2021.

The restrictions have come amid protests against the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls and demands for Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar's resignation across the country. They have brought the government's content-blocking powers, shorter compliance deadlines for intermediaries, and role of platforms' own automated moderation systems into focus.

What triggered the latest wave of takedowns? What did the Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology (MeitY) advisory to Meta say?

The latest wave follows two advisories issued by MeitY on October 8 and 10, amid anti-CEC protests. The October 8 advisory was addressed to social media platforms to exercise "enhanced diligence" over content relating to ongoing public events, contextualise misleading material, and prioritise complaints from authorised government agencies. It urged platforms to curb "manipulated or out-of-context content" on top of AI-generated deepfakes that are already liable for takedown notices under the amendments to the IT (Intermediary Guidelines and Digital Media Ethics Code) Rules.

Users can challenge restrictions imposed under Sections 69A and 79(3)(b) by questioning their legality, including through the courts where appropriate.



The logo of Meta seen at the entrance of the company's temporary stand ahead of the World Economic Forum in Davos, Switzerland in 2025. REUTERS

The October 10 advisory, issued by MeitY's Cyber Laws Division and addressed specifically to Meta, focused on how content was being distributed through feeds and recommendation systems. It said videos, images, statements, and graphics relating to public order and law-and-order situations were being prominently displayed and recommended to users. It advised Meta to identify and address content that could cause public disorder or incite violence or other unlawful activity; review its ranking and recommendation mechanisms; provide context for visuals whose authenticity, date, location, or circumstances were unclear; and ensure users were not disproportionately exposed to a single or limited set of narratives. It also asked Meta to cooperate with law-enforcement agencies within the timelines prescribed under the IT Rules.

The advisory called for immediate action and asked Meta to inform the Ministry of the measures taken. It also stated that lawful civic and public discourse should not be unnecessarily restricted.

How do the amended IT Rules make takedowns faster?

The IT (Intermediary Guidelines and Digital Media Ethics Code) Amendment Rules, 2026 tightened intermediary obligations, particularly in relation to synthetically generated information, including realistic AI-generated or altered audio-visual material.

Under amended Rule 3(1)(d), an intermediary that receives actual knowledge through a court order or a reasoned intimation from an authorised government officer or agency must remove or disable access to the specified unlawful information within three hours, down from 36 hours under the earlier framework. The amendments also shortened grievance-redressal timelines and introduced additional requirements for identifying and labelling permitted synthetic content. The changes leave platforms with considerably less time to assess a notice, determine its scope, and act on it.

Which laws allow the authorities to seek takedowns, and what safeguards apply?

Three provisions are central to understanding the restrictions: Section 69A of the IT Act, 2000; Rule 3(1)(d) of the IT Rules, 2021; and Section 79(3)(b) of the Act. Although all three can be relevant to the removal of online material, they serve different legal purposes.

Section 69A empowers the Central government or an officer specifically authorised by it to direct the blocking of public access to online information on specified grounds, including the sovereignty and integrity of India, defence, security of the State, friendly relations with foreign States, public order, and preventing incitement to certain offences.

Rule 3(1)(d), meanwhile, sets out the obligations of intermediaries after they receive a court order or a qualifying intimation from a relevant authorised authority concerning specified unlawful information.

Section 79 provides intermediaries with conditional protection from liability for third-party content. Under Section 79(3)(b), such protection may be affected if an intermediary fails to act after receiving the legally required notification concerning unlawful information.

Are the takedowns being driven by government orders?

The number of takedown notices issued by the unit declined during October as automated takedowns rose, according to an official from the Delhi Police's Intelligence Fusion and Strategic Operations unit. The Delhi Police have issued around 300 takedown requests in the past three months, with most acted upon by the platforms, according to sources. Law-enforcement agencies identify posts through routine monitoring, assess their content, and provide reasons when seeking their removal.

"The recent takedowns are a direct consequence of the advisory issued to Meta. The advisory seems to have been incorporated into Meta's community standards, contributing to restrictions imposed under the company's own policies," advocate Rishav Ranjan said.

What recourse do users have when their posts or accounts are blocked?

Users can challenge restrictions imposed under Sections 69A and 79(3)(b) by questioning their legality, including through the courts where appropriate. However, where content is restricted under a platform's own community standards, users are expected to approach the platform's grievance officer first and, if dissatisfied with the decision, appeal to the government's Grievance Appellate Committee.

Legal experts said this shift towards platform-level enforcement had made it more difficult for users to obtain timely relief.

"Now, users do not have the remedy in constitutional courts as Meta has taken up the exercise," Mr. Ranjan said. "Writing to a grievance officer often results in an automated acknowledgement, which can then be taken to the committee. The user is then required to wait for 30 days for a result. This adds 60-90 days before the appeal results in a solution. Meanwhile, the user's account remains blocked, in some cases impacting their livelihood and credibility."

Why is the NVS-03 satellite launch significant?

What is NavIC? What is its operational status? What does the NVS-03 satellite, which was launched on board the GSLV on October 30, carry? What corrective measures is ISRO attempting? Did recent launch failures affect the NVS-03 mission?

Jacob Koshy

The story so far:

The Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO) successfully launched the NVS-03 satellite from the Satish Dhawan Space Centre in Sriharikota on board the Geosynchronous Satellite Launch Vehicle (GSLV) on October 30. The launch will restore base-level functionality to India's indigenous 'GPS' system, called NavIC.

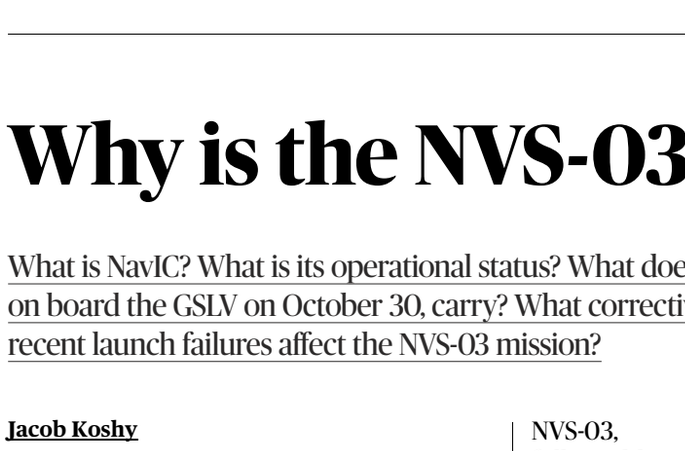
What is NavIC?

India launched the first-generation Indian Regional Navigation Satellite System (IRNSS) satellites between 2013 and 2018. They were designed to provide positioning, navigation and timing (PNT) services over India, to an area extending approximately 1,500 km beyond its boundaries. IRNSS was subsequently renamed NavIC, for 'Navigation with Indian Constellation'. Unlike the U.S. GPS, which has global coverage, NavIC was conceived as a regional system.

Satellite navigation systems generally provide two categories of signals: an open signal for civilian applications like navigation, transportation, disaster management, and telecommunications, and a restricted signal for authorised users, including the armed forces. The latter offers greater accuracy. For the armed forces, NavIC would offer a degree of operational independence.

NVS-03, followed by NVS-04 and NVS-05 — purportedly to be launched by December — are expected to help restore NavIC

However even with NVS-03, it will be a while before these loftier goals are realised.



The GSLV-F18 rocket carrying the NVS-03 satellite stands on the launch pad at the Satish Dhawan Space Centre ahead of liftoff, in Sriharikota. ANI

What is the operational status of NavIC?

Of the satellites launched under the original IRNSS programme, several have either been decommissioned, failed to reach their intended orbits, or have suffered failures of their onboard clocks. In July 2025, ISRO disclosed that five satellites were completely defunct, with all three clocks aboard each no longer functioning.

The situation deteriorated further in March, when the last functioning atomic clock aboard IRNSS-1F stopped working. The satellite, launched in 2016, had completed its designed mission life of 10 years three days prior. This left only three satellites able to provide PNT services. At least four are required for NavIC to function as intended.

There was also a setback in January 2025, when ISRO successfully placed the NVS-02 satellite in a geosynchronous transfer orbit, but the satellite's thrusters failed to move it into its intended final orbit.

What does NVS-03 carry?

NVS-03 is part of the second generation of satellites ISRO is developing to modernise NavIC. Each NVS satellite carries at least one indigenous rubidium atomic clock. Developed by the ISRO Space Applications Centre, these clocks are intended to replace the imported clocks made by Swiss company SpectraTime, used in the first generation IRNSS satellites.

The payload in Friday's launch consisted of imported and indigenous clocks, but ISRO has not shared more details.

Atomic clocks provide precise timing signals that allow receivers on the ground to calculate their position by measuring the time taken by signals to travel from satellites. Even a small timing error can translate into a significant positioning error.

What corrective measures is ISRO attempting?

NVS-01, launched in May 2023, was successfully placed in orbit and carries an indigenous rubidium atomic clock. NVS-02 was the second satellite in this series, but this mission's failure delayed subsequent launches. NVS-03, followed by NVS-04 and NVS-05 – purportedly to be launched by December – are expected to help restore NavIC.

ISRO's move towards indigenous clocks is also a corrective measure. It has also proposed increasing the number of clocks onboard each satellite to five, providing additional redundancy.

However, the indigenous clocks face procurement challenges. A March editorial in *The Hindu* argued that the transition to domestic manufacturing has not ensured a dependable supply of flight-ready equipment. ISRO also continues to function as both designer and operator of NavIC and, unlike the U.S. GPS Directorate or the European Union Agency for the Space Programme, lacks a dedicated counterpart to manage its navigation constellation.

Did recent launch failures affect the NVS-03 mission?

The NVS-03 launch comes against the backdrop of an unusually difficult period for ISRO. Two successive failures of the Polar Satellite Launch Vehicle (PSLV) forced the space agency to pause launches while a failure analysis committee investigated the causes.

The PSLV and GSLV are different rocket families but share aspects of their first-stage solid motor lineage, avionics, guidance systems, and manufacturing infrastructure. The government has said it has identified and resolved the causes of the failures but has declined to publish the committee's findings. ISRO has had only two successful launches this year, the other being the GSLV-F17 mission that launched the EOS-05 satellite.

The NVS-03 launch also departed from the usual spacecraft configuration, with ISRO having cleared a plan to fly it with its pyrotechnic valves already open, in a bid to avoid a recurrence of a problem that prevented NVS-02 from manoeuvring into its intended orbit.

PROFILES

The Pele of Brazil's politics

Lula da Silva

The left-wing leader's victory in Brazil, after finishing second in the first round, reflects the deep roots of the Workers' Party, which built its support base through resistance to the military dictatorship in the early 1980s, as well as the declining appeal of Bolsonarismo

Shobhan Saxena

ILLUSTRATION: R. RAJESH



With a smirk, Flávio Bolsonaro squinted at the camera and called President Lula da Silva "nine fingers" in the televised debate just two days before Brazil went to the polls for the presidential runoff. It was a cynical attempt to weaponise an old scar - and a gossip - against the Workers Party's leader. Lula reacted sharply, reminding the audience how he had lost a finger on his left hand while working in a factory. "If there is anyone who lost a finger at the age of 17, it was me, working at night because I had to work," Lula said, staring into the cameras. A red-faced Flavio didn't know where to look. On October 25, Lula made history by becoming the first Brazilian president to finish second in the first round of an election, held on October 4, and go on to win the presidency in the run-off.

Ever since Lula entered politics more than three decades ago, his opponents have peddled the rumour that he deliberately chopped off his own finger to gain sympathy and claim compensation. But those familiar with his life know the struggles that shaped him. Born on October 27, 1945, in a dusty corner of Brazil, Lula grew up amid hunger and deprivation in the state of Pernambuco.

His family migrated to São Paulo in search of a better life, joining thousands who fled the region trapped in poverty and hopelessness. Raised by his mother, Dona Lindu, whose resilience left a lasting impression on him, Lula received only primary education before joining the workforce as a teenager. His mother passed away at 64 in 1980, while Lula was in prison during a workers' strike. "I believe in a more just country because one day my mother taught me that, even in a simple home, no one can give up," Lula said on Mother's Day this year, fighting back tears as he remembered Dona Lindu.

Lula's journey - from a parched corner of Brazil to the industrial belt of Sao Paulo - was brought to life in *Lula, the Son of Brazil*, a 2010 film directed by Fábio Barreto. Tracking his life, the film showed how Lula's political training began on the factory floors of Sao Paulo's industrial region known for its massive factories.

Amid the clutter of machines and the daily struggle with poverty, Lula rose from an apprentice to a metalworker and trade union leader and became the voice of workers who were not willing to accept low wages and political exclusion. "During the late 1970s, as Brazil's military dictatorship sought to contain dissent, Lula emerged as one of the most prominent figures in the labour movement. His leadership brought him into direct confrontation with the regime and in 1980 he was arrested for his role in the strikes," said Mr. Barreto.

The foundation

The struggle of workers led to an event that would change Brazil's destiny forever. On February 10, 1980, more than 600 people, including trade unionists, intellectuals, church leaders and human rights activists, met on the campus of a Catholic school in Sao Paulo to declare the founding of the Workers' Party (PT).

As the charter of the new party was being discussed, Lula, one of the principal movers behind the idea of PT, sat among the audience rather than at the main table, reinforcing the idea that the party should grow from collective participation. With its manifesto calling for a mass movement for workers' emancipation and democracy with people's participation, the PT became the platform from which Lula launched his political career and eventually reached the presidency.

Since that day in 1980, Lula's political trajectory has been inseparable from that of the Workers Party. His successive presidential campaigns in the late 1980s and 1990s, as military dictatorship came to an end, transformed him from a trade union leader into a national political figure and turned the PT into a major political force across Brazil. In his 2020 book *Lula and His Politics of Cunning: From Metalworker to President of Brazil*, U.S. academic John D. French examined how industrialisation and workers' aspirations to get ahead in life shaped Lula's political instincts. Mr. French, who spent years studying Brazil's labour movement, argues that repression taught labour leaders negotiation, adaptability and guile. Mr. French compares Lula to Pelé, Brazil's legendary footballer, calling him the "Pelé of politics" – a master of his craft, able to read situations, anticipate others' moves and navigate difficult circumstances.

Armed with these qualities and backed by Brazil's working class and the poor, Lula assumed the presidency in 2003, ushering in a defining era for Brazil and the PT. His two terms (2003-2010) and Dilma Rousseff's presidency (2011-16) consolidated the PT's place at the centre of national politics. But Jair Bolsonaro's victory in 2018, on an anti-PT platform, posed the biggest threat yet to the party's political dominance, marking a sharp rightward shift in Brazil. Lula's return to presidency in 2023, after his imprisonment on unsubstantiated charges and acquittal, demonstrated that the PT remained a formidable force even in a deeply-polarised country.

A new mandate

Rejuvenated by Lula's election victory in 2022, the PT has now received a massive mandate in last week's election, opening a new chapter in its trajectory. The victory has given the party, whose base is now much bigger and diverse than it was 20 years ago, an opportunity to prepare for the period after Lula's fourth term. With younger voters and more digital engagement, the PT may be now on the cusp of a transformation. "In this election I have learned a lot from the young. In my fourth mandate, my government will focus more on people and their needs, and we will see more young leaders," Lula said after beating Flavio.

While his rival has fled to Miami, Lula's journey from the factory gates of São Paulo to presidential palace continues. The significance of his victory extends beyond the country's borders. For millions around the world, Lula's victory represents a triumph of democracy against the far-right, achieved despite pressure from U.S. President Donald Trump and interference by Big Tech. Former Brazilian minister José Dirceu describes Lula as a truly global leader. "Lula's political journey and electoral victories represent a milestone in the struggle for democracy and against hunger and inequality, serving as a reference point in the fight against the rise of the far-right in several countries," he says.

The Brazilian election verdict is clear: the factory worker from Sao Paulo and Workers Party remain at the centre of Brazil's politics, while Bolsonarismo faces an uncertain future.

THE GIST

- On February 10, 1980, more than 600 people, including trade unionists, intellectuals, church leaders and rights activists, met on the campus of a Catholic school in Sao Paulo to declare the founding of the Workers' Party
- With its manifesto calling for a mass movement for workers' emancipation and democracy, the PT became the platform from which Lula launched his political career and eventually reached the presidency
- Successive presidential campaigns in the 1980s and 1990s, as military dictatorship came to an end, transformed him from a trade union leader into a national figure, and turned the PT into a major political force across Brazil

The surge of the other

Ra'am and Joint List

Israel's Arab parties made historic gains in elections but uncertainty remains whether the opposition bloc would join hands with them to form a government

Sambavi Parthasarathy

AFP



On October 27, the day Israel went to the polls, the first election since the October 7, 2023 Hamas attack, the country recorded its highest voter turnout since 1999, at 77.7% But this was not the only story about the turnout.

Israel's often overlooked Arab citizens, who make up some 20% of the population, made an overwhelming case for representation and change that day by turning out in massive numbers to vote. Exit polls recorded by Channel 12 estimated their turnout at nearly 80%, the highest in at least a decade.

For the far-right coalition led by Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu, the election was a "war for our home", but for Arab parties, the political mobilisation meant meaningful representation in the Knesset, the Israeli parliament.

This mobilisation seems to have paid off. Arab parties have emerged as the third bloc after the elections. The Joint List and the United Arab List (Ra'am) have secured a combined 19 seats in the 120-member Parliament, their highest-ever tally.

Part of the credit goes to the Arab parties, which have actively mobilised their communities to vote. But much of it also goes to Mr. Netanyahu's far-right government, whose policies and rhetoric, including the war on Gaza and escalating violence in the occupied West Bank, have heightened fears among Arab citizens.

While Arab citizens are affected like any other Israelis when it comes to national security, they've also borne the brunt of racism and violence. According to polls by the Israeli Democracy Institute, a party's position related to crime in Arab society was one of the most important factors determining their vote.

Prime motivation

Fear, as many experts have pointed out, has been their prime motivation, which Arab parties have been able to mobilise given the divisive campaigns launched by Mr. Netanyahu's bloc. During the campaign, the Netanyahu camp put up billboards, saying it was 'either the right or Palestine'. Even on the day of polling, the Prime Minister urged his supporters to go and vote, pointing to an Arab voter surge and calling it a matter of "life and death".

While leaders of Arab parties have called Mr. Netanyahu's attempts racist, they, too, have borne the brunt of discrimination. Like in the cases of previous elections, an attempt was made for disqualification of the Ra'am party and the Joint List (an alliance of Balad, Hadash and Ta'al) before the polls. The surge in voter turnout has helped them gain a significant number of seats, which would have made them kingmakers in a hung Parliament where no bloc has a clear majority. But neither side has expressed any willingness to form a government with Arab parties.

Mr. Netanyahu has accused the Arab parties of "stealing" the elections and has vowed to keep them out of power, while Gadi Eisenkot, leader of the opposition coalition, has been reluctant to join hands with them.

This reluctance is not new. The Ra'am party, led by Mansour Abbas, became the first Arab party in nearly 44 years to be part of a government in 2021 when they backed the Bennett-Yair Lapid government. Ra'am broke off from the Joint List. However, this experiment was short-lived as the coalition collapsed within a year. Ra'am returned to the opposition fold after Mr. Netanyahu's coalition won the elections in 2022.

Arab parties had previously supported governments from outside, especially under Labour Prime Minister Yitzhak Rabin.

For Arab parties, the question of coalition is not an easy take either. Any alliance with Jewish parties is challenging given how much they differ in their views on Palestine. Most Jewish parties, including Mr. Netanyahu's Likud and Mr. Eisenkot's Yashar, are opposed to the establishment of a Palestinian State and support the occupation of the West Bank.

This is in contrast to what the Arab parties envision. The Joint List has stated that it is committed to ending the occupation and establishing a Palestinian state along the 1967 borders and lifting the siege on Gaza. Ra'am supports an end of the occupation and the establishment of a Palestinian state with Jerusalem as its capital. However, they differ on priorities. While Mansour Abbas's Ra'am party prioritises tackling immediate, practical resources for Arab towns, the Joint List maintains that Arab citizens cannot achieve true equality inside Israel without also ending the military occupation of Palestinians in the West Bank and Gaza.

The young Serb unrest

Student List

Serbia's student protesters, who built a blockade movement against corruption and political establishment, brought down the government of Aleksandar Vučić

Joan Sony Cherian

AFP



On November 1, 2024, the concrete canopy of the Novi Sad Railway station in Serbia came crashing down, killing 16 people. Two of the youngest victims were just six years old. What began as grief and mourning over a tragedy has since brought an end to 14 years of rule by the Serbian Progressive Party (SNS), led by Aleksandar Vučić.

Before the collapse, the Novi Sad railway station had recently been reconstructed as part of a major state-funded project, backed by China's Belt and Road Initiative, to upgrade the railway line between Belgrade and Budapest for high-speed rail services. Outrage over the shoddy reconstruction led to allegations of corruption and government negligence, which resulted in widespread protests.

By December 2024, students started blockading university spaces and halting classes, demanding transparency over the renovation project and the prosecution of all those responsible for the collapse. There were also symbolic protests. For example, every day at 11.52 a.m. (the time of the collapse), protesters would observe 16 minutes of silence for the 16 victims.

Mr. Vučić, who became Deputy Prime Minister in 2012, later became Prime Minister and then, in 2017, was elected President of Serbia. His rule has been characterised as authoritarian due to democratic backsliding, restriction on media freedoms and curtailing of civic liberties.

By January 2025, the protests had snowballed into a larger grassroots movement against corruption. Even as Prime Minister Milos Vucevic resigned in January 2025, the movement did not stall. It continued to appeal to the masses and conducted plenums in order to flesh out its demands more concretely. Through such plenums, the 'leaderless' and 'faceless' movement brought everyone into the ambit of decision-making, giving students a sense of ownership about the protests.

They organised rallies and marathons in order to spread the message. They were even able to call on people in large towns and small villages to set up their own local citizen groups. In May 2025, the student movement formally demanded the resignation of the government and called for snap elections.

Even though these protests, some of which were massive in scale, with more than 1 lakh people showing up in Belgrade, were met with police action leading to several students and journalists getting injured, the fervour of the movement didn't abate. The momentum kept brewing throughout these two years. An October 30, 2025 analysis by ACLED stated that between November 1, 2024 and October 24, 2025, more than 2,400 demonstrations took place against the government across Serbia.

Electoral victory

When snap elections were finally announced, on September 9, 2026, the students made their own list of candidates for the 250 seats in the Serbian Parliament: the 'Student List - Students Are Winning'. Since the students themselves had no experience in public life, they made a list of renowned academics, civic personalities and even actors who would stand for their needs and demands. Their programme involves a 11-point plan divided into three sections, which demands full transparency in public procurement and audit of state projects, freeing the media, permanent employment contracts after 12 months, and affordable housing among others.

The lead candidate selected by the students on the list is cardiologist Ilija Srdanović, a prominent face during the protests. Other candidates on the list include Radomir Saicic, a chemistry professor, Dejan Bodiroga, a former basketball player, and Dejan Šoškić, a former governor of the National Bank of Serbia. One clear requirement for the candidates was that they should have no political affiliation. This is emblematic of the suspicion with which the Serbian political class as a whole is seen in the country.

The elections, conducted on October 25, saw the victory of the student movement with the Student List winning 141 seats while the SNS won 103. Other opposition parties barely scraped by with just one or two seats. The student movement was jubilant with Mr. Saicic reflecting the mood: "Students won and with them also hope that Serbia can be a country of justice, freedom and dignity".

Mr. Vučić, however, while conceding the election, told party supporters that the movement had destroyed two years of life in Serbia and that they would be defeated "faster than they think".

Indian scientists find new gateway in plants' alarm system

Jacob Koshy

Researchers at the National Institute of Plant Genome Research (NIPGR), New Delhi, have identified a previously uncharacterised protein that helps a plant warn undamaged leaves when an insect attacks one.

The finding may have implications for designing chemicals to help plants fend off pest attacks.

Plants too don't like to be preyed upon by other insects or herbivores. They also can't flee and have no nervous system, yet a bite on one leaf can set off an alarm that reaches other leaves within minutes.

The prevailing view credits a family of cellular gateways, glutamate receptor-like channels (GLRs), that respond to the amino acid glutamate and relay the alarm.

The study, published in *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences,* points to another protein: CNGC13, which sits mainly in the xylem and phloem and lets calcium into cells as the damage signal passes along the plant.

"Our study identifies an important role for a calcium channel, CNGC13, in coordinating systemic calcium signalling during insect herbivory," Jyothilakshmi Vadassery, one of the study co-authors, said in a statement. "The findings provide new insights into how plants communicate danger signals across tissues."

Spreading the warning

At the site of attack, calcium, reactive oxygen species and hormones such as jasmonic acid switch on defence genes and reinforce cell walls, sealing the wound and blocking pathogens. If the damage is serious, hydraulic, electrical, calcium, and reactive oxygen signals carry the alert to distant tissue. Warned leaves can raise their glucosinolate levels and grow more leaf hairs, making them more resistant to herbivores.

Some plants also release airborne chemicals that warn nearby tissue and attract the insects' natural enemies, per a review in the journal *Frontiers in Plant Science*.

According to the new paper, insect pests cause roughly 20% of global annual crop losses, a figure projected to rise with warming, and crop protection still leans heavily on chemical insecticides. Learning how plants sense attack could point to crops that defend themselves better.

CNGC13 test

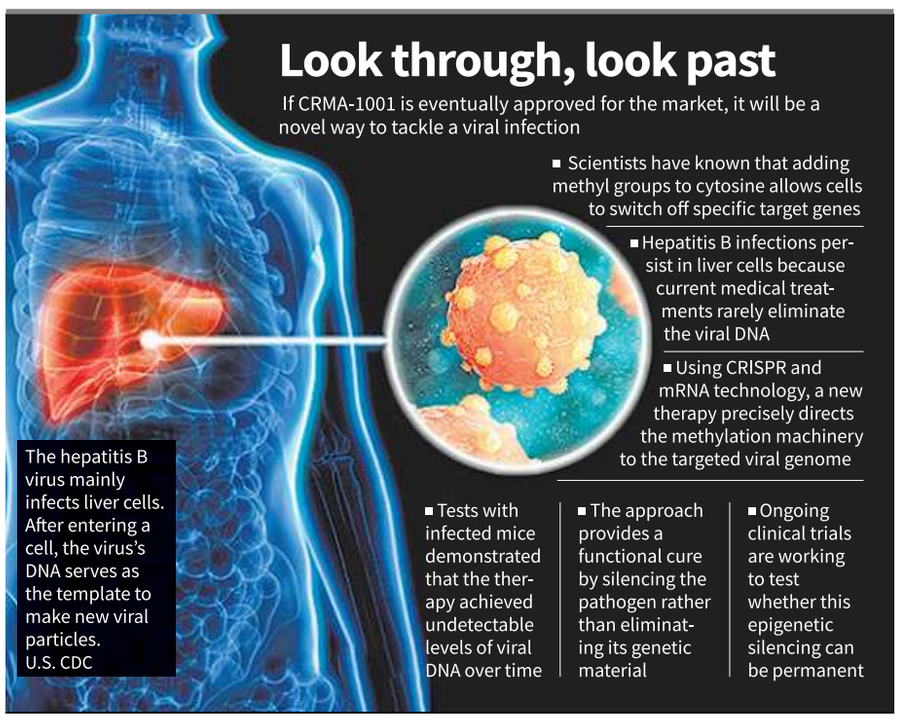
The authors say the speed and robustness of systemic responses to different kinds of damage suggested that other channels were involved. To establish the CNGC13 channel's role, researchers compared normal *Arabidopsis,* a small weed from the mustard family, with three mutant lines lacking CNGC13. Larvae of *Spodoptera litura*, which played the plant's attacker, gained significantly more weight on all three mutant lines. Restoring the gene in one line returned weight gain to normal, indicating the channel is needed for resistance.

Gene therapy aims for a cure by silencing hepatitis B DNA

An experimental therapy called CRMA-1001 is a remarkable development because, instead of targeting the virus directly, it silences the viral DNA; this is promising because treatments rarely eliminate the DNA, which allows the virus to rebound

Arun Panchapakesan

According to new work reported in *Nature Biomedical Engineering*, scientists have used epigenetic control to treat a hepatitis B infection. The development is remarkable because, instead of targeting the virus directly, the work silenced the viral DNA. This is promising because current treatments rarely eliminate the DNA, which allows the virus to rebound. By silencing this residue, the treatment could offer a path to a lasting functional cure for hepatitis B.



Virus in hiding

The hepatitis B virus mainly infects liver cells. After entering a cell, the virus's DNA serves as the template to make new viral particles. In many people, the immune system clears the infection, but if it does not, the viral DNA can persist for years or even decades in the host's liver.

In this time, the virus can remain silent, meaning the viral DNA is still present in the cell but its genes are not active to produce new viruses. This allows the virus to 'hide' from the immune system. Then, at a later point, the virus can activate again and produce new virus particles.

Studies have shown that one of the mechanisms by which the virus stays silent is by methylating cytosines.

DNA is segmented into genes, and each gene contains the information necessary to make a particular protein. These proteins essay their roles in the cells. Since every cell in the body has two copies – one from each parent – of all human DNA, all cells technically have the blueprint to make a whole organism. However, cells also have specialised functions: a brain cell does not need the genes for the proteins used to digest food.

One of DNA's four building blocks is cytosine. Cells can attach a chemical tag, like the methyl group ($-CH_3$), to cytosine to silence the corresponding gene. This prevents the cell's protein factory from reading the gene and the cell from making that protein. Problems in this epigenetic system can lead to diseases like cancers.

The new study has reported a new experimental therapy called CRMA-1001 that can reportedly silence the DNA of the hepatitis B virus by selectively methylating the virus's genome.

The study's authors combined two molecular components to achieve this, called a 'locator' and an 'effector'. The locator used the CRISPR-Cas9 gene-editing tool to find and bind to a specific DNA sequence: in this case, a sequence within the viral DNA. This allowed the CRISPR system to take the 'effector', the methylation machinery, to the correct location. The effector had proteins that could add methyl groups to nearby cytosines in the viral DNA and proteins that help switch off genes. Finally, the researchers packed the entire system and delivered it on an mRNA platform. Once a cell had read the instructions to make the required proteins, it degraded them, stopping the production of those proteins too.

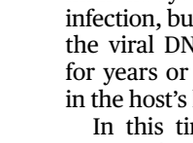
The researchers gave mice infected with hepatitis B virus either a single dose of CRMA-1001 or three doses, one month apart, and regularly tested them for six months for the signs of infection. They reported that after one dose, the levels of several hepatitis B virus markers, including the viral DNA and two viral proteins called HBsAg and HBeAg, dropped significantly. When they tested the viral DNA, they found new methyl groups, suggesting the treatment was working as intended. The effect was even stronger after three doses: six months after the first dose, as many as 90% of the animals had less viral DNA than could be detected.

CRMA-1001 is not a cure in the traditional sense of the word. The hepatitis B virus DNA is still present in the liver cells. Instead, the study demonstrated a functional cure: when the virus is not necessarily eliminated but is kept so thoroughly suppressed that, for all intents and purposes, the patient has no active signs of disease. In this study, the team followed up with the mice for six months after treatment, and the researchers found sustained suppression of the virus in that period. However, the study did not establish whether the virus could eventually become active again after those six months, since the viral DNA was still present.

Further studies are needed to examine the long-term effects of CRMA-1001, including whether the silencing effect can persist over many years and whether the virus can ever become active again after treatment. An ongoing phase I/II clinical trial includes these among other questions. Nonetheless, CRMA-1001 represents a novel way to tackle a viral infection: instead of fighting the threat, the cell simply ignores it.

(Arun Panchapakesan is an assistant professor at the Y.R. Gaitonde Centre for AIDS Research and Education, Chennai)

Greener cities and bluer spaces for a healthier India



SPEAKING OF SCIENCE

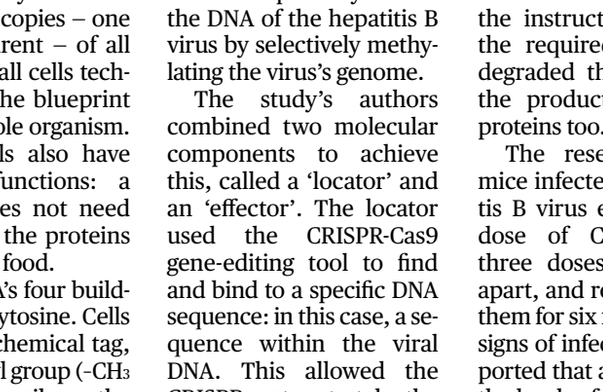
D. Balasubramanian

Green trees and plants are vital for human health. In villages and farmlands, the uppermost parts of the tree provide a canopy, with roof-like branches, offering people a cooler and healthier environment. And the rivers, canals, ponds and pools offer people there a bluer environment.

Such rural areas thus offer their residents healthier environs. But when private enterprises and commercial agencies take away many acres of land in towns, suburban, and rural areas to build large multi-storied buildings and housing complexes, it results in further canopy loss. The State of Telangana has about 48% of the people living in urban areas, with more trees sacrificed, while farmlands and villages are left with fewer trees and less water for agriculture. This is also true of several other southern States.

The urban population across India is now 36%. UNICEF has pointed out that children's health is affected when green and blue spaces are disturbed. According to the National Family Health Survey, the infant mortality rate can be correlated to the greenness of the area; the lower the greenness, the higher the rate. In the green States of Kerala, Goa and Puducherry, the infant mortality rate is quite low, around eight per 1,000 births, while Uttar Pradesh and Rajasthan have higher rates, closer to thirty per 1,000 births.

In 2023, an international team of researchers pointed out in the journal *The Lancet* (vol. 8, issue 9, September 2023) that since a significant fraction of the human population now lives in urban areas, these people should also enjoy greater access to urban green and blue spaces, which could lead to improvements in public health. It will also promote environmental biodiversity and civic sense through parks, sports fields, higher physical activity, and camaraderie among the residents.



Shrinking spaces: UNICEF has pointed out that children's health is affected when green and blue spaces are disturbed. V. RAJU

A more recent paper by three Indian researchers in the *Indian Journal of Science and Research* (Pande et al; *Ind. J. Sci. Res.*, 5 (2), 2025) expanded on this theme and suggested a framework to achieve green infrastructure and urban sustainability. This involves greener urban areas, including more trees, parks, walkways, sports arenas, and swimming pools. These have now become part of the Indian government's Atal Mission for Rejuvenation and Urban Transformation (AMRUT).

In this connection, recently, an international group of epidemiologists analysed data from 57 countries. Their findings, published in *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences*, under the title 'Urban tree canopy fragmentation and child mortality in low- and middle-income countries' (*PNAS*, 123 (34) e2606669123, August 21, 2026), show how the loss of green and blue spaces through the loss of canopy can affect children's health by increasing climate stress, air pollution, anxiety, loss of playground space and infection by pests and microbes. These factors can also lead to low birthweight, psychological stress, congenital anomalies, and child mortality, notably under the age of five. The researchers collected data from 42 lakh children hailing from 57 low- and middle-income countries or regions where green and blue spaces are more prevalent, such as in West Sudan, the Punjab region in Pakistan, and the Ganga-Brahmaputra Delta in Bangladesh, and found that these regions have lower levels of under-five mortality than in the other countries studied.

According to the World Bank, India ranks as the fifth wealthiest nation in the world. Even as we aim to make India rank higher, let us ensure the country becomes greener and bluer.

dbala@lvpei.org

SNAPSHOTS



Even in desert, early humans sought more than water

More than water alone guided humans in the ancient Arabian Peninsula. Scientists earlier believed human populations expanded across 'Green Arabia' wherever lakes formed. But after surveying a 1,500-km stretch in the Rub' al Khali desert, researchers found evidence of 55 extinct lakes but no stone tools or signs of life. Since early humans relied on stone tools for survival, the team concluded human migration was guided by the availability of both water and toolmaking stones.



Faux references getting more common in science papers

An analysis of 5 lakh peer-reviewed papers in physics, chemistry, materials science, engineering, and computer science published in 2023-26 has revealed 1,135 fake references in 619 papers. The rate of papers containing such citations increased from roughly 6 of every 10,000 papers in 2023 to 23 out of 10,000 in 2026. Physics had the highest rate of fake references and chemistry had the lowest. These fictional citations often stem from the unchecked use of AI tools or misconduct.



Manx shearwaters risk jet-lag on long-distance flights

Seabirds called Manx shearwaters can become 'jet-lagged' during long, fast flights, momentarily veering off course. They fly across oceans using an internal body clock that synchronises with daylight. But when they fly east or west across longitudes, the clocks fall out of sync with the local time. Using GPS data from over a thousand birds, scientists found the internal clocks of shearwaters flying east lagged, causing the birds to drift clockwise from their intended path.

Question Corner

Only change is constant

Have humans stopped evolving? If not, what traits are changing?
– Anand Songara, Indore

Humans are still evolving – through new mutations, natural selection, migration, and random chance.

Put one way, evolution can be discerned from changes in the frequencies of the genetic variants passed down through the generations. But this process is too slow to detect within a single human lifetime.

But one good example of something we know has changed is the ability of human adults to digest milk. Most mammals lose their ability to digest lactose after weaning, but in the last several millennia, genetic variants have allowed this ability to last longer in some human populations.

In an another example, humans have evolved through the way they resisted infectious diseases. In regions where malaria is endemic, people with one copy of the sickle-cell variant have some protection against severe malaria.

Overall, evolution has no predetermined direction, so it is hard to predict how humans will change in the coming millennia.

Readers may send their questions / answers to science@thehindu.co.in

INBRIEF



Petrol export duty cut to nil, diesel levy raised by ₹3 a litre

The government slashed export duty on petrol to nil while hiking that on export of diesel and aviation turbine fuel (ATF) by ₹3/litre and 50 paise/litre each for the next 15 days. There was no change in existing excise duty rates for petrol and diesel for local use. Diesel exports would now draw a levy of ₹11.5/litre against ₹8.5/ litre it in the previous fortnight. ATF would be subject to an export levy of ₹11/litre against ₹10.5/litre as mandated for the previous fortnight.

Government extends import duty exemption for cotton

The Finance Ministry extended the import duty on cotton until December 31 providing relief to the largest cotton consumer—the textile industry. In a notification issued on October 30, the Ministry said the exemption, which was granted in May this year, would now extend to the end of December. With poor Southwest monsoon impacting cotton crop, daily arrivals of cotton remain low though the new cotton marketing season began on October 1.

NTPC Q2 net rises 14% on more generation, efficiencies

State-owned power producer NTPC Ltd.'s standalone net profit rose 14.3% year-on-year (YoY) to ₹5,320 crore in the September quarter, aided by higher electricity generation and improved operational efficiencies amid increased power demand following deficient monsoon rainfall. The company's commercial generation increased 11.1% to 92.413 billion units (BU) during the quarter. Its plant load factor (PLF) improved to 73.53% from 66.01% a year-earlier.

Merging SpaceX, Tesla makes more sense for Elon Musk than its investors

Merger will up vertical integration across technologies like communications, computing infra, which many governments rely on, raising risk of preferential access, discrimination; Starlink, Starshield services may also depend on decisions made within a corporate system that includes X.com

NEWS ANALYSIS

Vasudevan Mukunth
CHENNAI

American billionaire Elon Musk's plan to merge his spaceflight and satellite-Internet company SpaceX with his electric vehicle maker Tesla will concentrate a huge amount of technological financial power in his hands with a combined market capitalisation of $3.5 trillion. Importantly, it will create a new integrated AI-industrial conglomerate.

Both firms have committees of independent directors to figure it out and no particular terms are in play. SpaceX also disclosed Mr. Musk, the controlling shareholder, will have to okay the merger though he has recused himself from committees' negotiations.

SpaceX has already absorbed xAI, that operates Grok AI model, in February while Tesla is developing specialised AI chips. The firms also jointly announced an ambitious semiconductor manufacturing project called Terafab. So, a merger will bring multiple verticals under the same corporate roof.

Remove capital checks

But while the merger will ease these operations' ability to move money and personnel between them, it could also eliminate crucial checks on how the combined behemoth allocates capital – a non-trivial prospect considering Mr. Musk's latent fondness for testing the rules.

For example, *CNBC* reported in 2024 Mr. Musk diverted 12,000 Nvidia H100 processors meant for Tesla towards X.com and xAI, reportedly delaying Tesla's receipt of over $500 million computing equipment by months. He later said Tesla lacked the infrastructure to use the processors when Nvidia delivered them. In January 2026, Tesla committed $2 billion to xAI and when SpaceX acquired xAI, Tesla turned its right to buy xAI shares into a right to buy SpaceX shares. Neither of the transactions was illegal per se but they hint simultaneously at the movement of resources and (reduced) exposure to scrutiny that could ensue post-merger.

A more important possibility is if Tesla is being moved to within a larger enterprise to finance ambitions its shareholders have not supported thus far. For example, at the November 2025 Tesla investors' meeting, a proposal to authorise it to invest in xAI failed under the firm's voting rules. Tesla, however, entered into the $2-billion investment pact in January as the vote was non-binding.

To wit, the firms' financial circumstances differ hugely. "SpaceX's year-on-year revenue growth in Q3 2026 was 161% while Tesla's was roughly 0%. Tesla's current value far exceeds what its current earnings would justify as the variance is rooted in speculation about autonomous vehicles and AI integration. Analysts have also said SpaceX shareholders could find themselves surrendering a significant share of what has become a highly profitable business to Tesla's more speculative future earning.



Power and more: Founder, CEO, chairman, and chief engineer of SpaceX, Elon Musk at SpaceX's IPO on the Nasdaq. REUTERS (FILE)

No majority but control

Further, Mr. Musk now owns about 20% of Tesla but has voting control at SpaceX with 85%. But per Barclays, depending on the post-merger structure, he could own 37% of the combined firm's equity but 56% of voting power. That is, Mr. Musk could consolidate control over an enterprise worth many trillions of dollars without holding a majority of economic value. One crucial result of that may be a newfound ability to finance firms whose economic or institutional rationale is questionable, whose political importance for Mr. Musk is significant and for which he can skip the support of other shareholders.

A similar issue came up in 2016 when Tesla bought solar power firm SolarCity, setting off years of investor litigation. Mr. Musk was at the time Tesla's chairman and CEO and SolarCity's chairman and largest investor. SolarCity was facing significant liquidity problems and Tesla had agreed to buy it in an all-stock transaction worth $2.6 billion but without appointing an independent committee to negotiate. For added measure, SolarCity was being run by Mr. Musk's cousins Lyndon Rive and Peter Rive.

A court ultimately ruled in Mr. Musk's favour after investors alleged he used Tesla to 'salvage' his investments in SolarCity but not before identifying several lacunae in the acquisition process, including conflicts of interest. (Per the court, Mr. Musk was nonetheless served well by having a majority of disinterested Tesla shareholders approve the deal.)

Tech integration

A closely related issue is the merger could raise vertical integration across technologies like communications and computing infrastructure – that many other businesses as well as governments rely on – raising the risk of preferential access and discrimination. (*Reuters* also reported the merger could prompt demands for extensive safeguards around information and technology sharing between SpaceX's and Tesla's U.S. and China operations.) Seen another way, many services of strategic importance, including Starlink and Starshield, could depend on decisions made within one corporate system that also includes X.com.

Dangerous prospect

A recent example of the stakes concerns Starshield. *The Wall Street Journal* reported on October 20 Mr. Musk personally asked operators at SpaceX to limit connectivity of Ukrainian drones to its network after his as well as U.S. President Donald Trump's frustration over Kyiv attacking Russian oil refineries. While there appears to be some confusion over who first gave the order – Mr. Musk or someone in the White House – the merger could boost the corporation at its centre by bringing together aerospace, telecommunications, AI, robotics, computing hardware, power generation, and the requisite funds.

The final prospect is as dangerous as it is dazzling: a firm that governments bank on for strategic capabilities yet which they cannot castigate without threatening their own interests – the ultimate expression of Mr. Musk's parastate actions in Ukraine.

Considering SpaceX and Tesla already collaborate as well as can expand cooperation via contracts, and if their technological benefits are available to reap without merging, those benefits alone will not suffice to explain why the companies prefer or need a merger. The answer, instead, might be what Mr. Musk needs.

Crude oil prices very volatile in Q2: IOCL

Saptaparno Ghosh
NEW DELHI

Crude oil prices stayed highly volatile in Q2 with procurement carried out varyingly at discounts and premiums, Anuj Jain, director (finance) at Indian Oil Corporation Ltd. (IOCL) told investors in a call.

Mr. Jain explained broadly crude procured during Q2 held both discounts and premiums at varying periods. This entailed a discount of $5/barrel to the then benchmark prices to a premium of $12/barrel. This ranged from no discount/premium to a premium of $18/barrel in Q1. He also informed under-recoveries on liquefied petroleum gas (LPG) stood at ₹184/cylinder in September and rose to ₹229 in October. Also, he projected the under-recoveries could rise to ₹309/cylinder in November and ₹370 per cylinder in December.

Further, Russian crude accounted for around 55% of IOCL's crude basket during H1, Middle East 24%, Africa – including Angola and Nigeria – about 10%, Brazil about 7% with U.S. and Venezuela making up the remainder 2-5% and 3-4%, respectively.

Food for thought



Body, soul together: A woman carries of a box of donated food at Bounty Soul food bank in North Carolina. The nonprofit says October is busiest month on record. It expects to serve about 26,000 people, up from roughly 24,500 in October 2025. Food banks across U.S. are under increasing strain as more people seek assistance amid cuts to federal nutrition programmes and rising cost of living. GETTY IMAGES VIA AFP

'Keeping eye on Tata Group developments'

Press Trust of India
KOLKATA

SEBI Chairman Tuhin Kanta Pandey said the market regulator was monitoring developments relating to governance at the holding company level in the Tata Group and pointed out the group's listed companies and their promoters were subject to SEBI's disclosure and compliance norms.

The comments came amid differences over governance matters at Tata Sons, the group's holding company, including the reappointment of N. Chandrasekaran as chairman and the proposed listing.



Tuhin Kanta Pandey

"At the holding company level, there are some issues as that's not really a listed firm. The rest of the firms, those which are listed, follow all LODR (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) norms."

ECV maker EKA Mobility plans ₹1,000-crore R&D investment

Jagriti Chandra
PUNE

Electric commercial vehicle (ECV) maker EKA Mobility plans to invest ₹1,000 crore in research and development (R&D) over the next four to five years as it steps up manufacturing capacity and seeks to expand domestic and overseas footprint, founder chairman Sudhir Mehta said.

The Pune-based firm inaugurated six new manufacturing plants across Maharashtra and Madhya Pradesh, taking annual production capacity to 40,000 vehicles. The expanded capacity comprises 24,000 small commercial vehicles, 10,000 buses and 6,000 trucks.

Road Transport and Highways Minister Nitin Gadkari, Heavy Industries Minister H. D. Kumaraswamy and Maharashtra CM Devendra Fadnavis were present.



EKA has an order book of more than 11,000 buses valued at $1.7 billion

"EKA aims to scale up sales to match this capacity by 2030," Mr. Mehta told journalists. A subsidiary of automotive components maker Pinnacle Industries, EKA invested ₹3,500 crore in the business so far.

Japan's Mitsui & Co and the Netherlands-based VDL Groep are strategic partners. The firm, which has presence in Zanzibar and Nepal, aims at raising exports to 20-30% of total sales over next few years. It is exploring more opportunities in Africa "We are looking at Ghana, Ethiopia, Uganda and many African markets, basically, much of West and South Africa," Mr. Mehta said.

EKA has an order book of more than 11,000 buses valued at $1.7 billion, with deployments across 14 States. It has also sold more than 1,500 electric small commercial vehicles for passenger mobility, last-mile delivery and goods transportation across the country.

On policy support for the ECV industry, Mr. Mehta flagged the limited availability of financing as a key constraint to faster adoption and expansion.

(The reporter was in Pune at the invitation of Eka Mobility)

Taxes: Centre releases ₹1.09 lakh cr. more to States

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

The Centre released an additional instalment of tax devolution to State governments totalling more than ₹1.09 lakh crore.

This is in addition to the regular monthly devolution and the second additional instalment this financial year.

"This release is in view of the upcoming festive season and to enable States to accelerate capital spending, and also to finance their development/welfare related expenditure," the Finance Ministry said in a statement on Saturday.

Currently, 41% of the taxes collected by the Union government is devolved in 14 instalments among the States during a fiscal year.

Radico sets sights on Scotland for malt whisky supplies

Mini Tejaswi
BENGALURU

Radico Khaitan Ltd. has incorporated a Scotland-based subsidiary to explore opportunities in whisky distillation, maturation and trading, as the Indian spirits maker seeks to strengthen its malt whisky supply chain and expand overseas operations.

Abhishek Khaitan, MD, told *The Hindu* the company established Radico Khaitan Scotland Ltd. to evaluate opportunities in the country but was not pursuing any specific distillery acquisition at present.

"The Scotland initiative is also aimed at addressing the company's growing requirement for mature malt spirit," he said.

The proposed presence is expected to provide greater flexibility in sourcing, maturation and storage of malt spirit. However, Mr. Khaitan clarified the move would not alter the Indian provenance of its Rampur single malt whisky.



Abhishek Khaitan

Indian identity

"Rampur will continue to be distilled and matured in India, with its identity linked to the climate and provenance of the Himalayan foothills," he said.

The expansion comes as the company seeks to diversify its export markets. Its brands are now available in over 100 countries, with Africa, Asia-Pacific and travel retail identified as key growth areas.

"Recent disruptions in the West Asia and Gulf corridor highlighted the risks of concentration in individual markets," he said, adding the firm was working to strengthen distribution across other regions.

Radico Khaitan reported net revenue of more than ₹6,000 crore in FY26. Its Prestige & Above portfolio contributed 46% of Indian-made foreign liquor (IMFL) volumes and about 70% of value sales during the year.

The premium portfolio maintained its momentum in the first quarter of FY27, with volumes growing 35.8% to 5.22 million cases. Its contribution rose to 53% of IMFL volumes and 77% of value sales.

Granules facility gets 11 U.S. FDA observations

N. Ravi Kumar
HYDERABAD

Generic drugmaker Granules India's finished dosage facility in Gagillapur, Hyderabad, has been issued 11 observations by the U.S. Food and Drug Administration (U.S.FDA) following an inspection.

Conducted from October 19-30, the current good manufacturing practice inspection (CGMP) concluded with the issuance of a Form FDA 483 containing 11 observations. It was the first U.S. FDA inspection, of the facility, since the February 26, 2025, warning letter that followed an inspection in August-September 2024.

None of the observations were related to data integrity or cross-contamination.

DHAKA

Opposition leader in Bangladesh warns against India corridor: report



REUTERS

Nahid Islam, an Opposition leader in Bangladesh and convener of National Citizen Party, has warned against any move to facilitate an Indian transit corridor through the country and called for a fair water-sharing agreement with New Delhi ahead of the expiry of the Ganges treaty in December, according to *Prothom Alo*. PTI

BRASILIA

Flavio says he left Brazil because he is a victim of 'persecution'



AFP

Former conservative presidential candidate Flavio Bolsonaro said on Friday that he fled Brazil to the United States because he was a victim of "persecution" in his country. Mr. Bolsonaro, who lost the election runoff to President Luiz Inacio Lula da Silva, secretly left Brazil on Tuesday and arrived in Florida aboard a private jet. AFP

NAIROBI

United Nations ends its Somalia political mission after 3 decades



AFP

The United Nations political mission in Somalia ended on Saturday after a two-year transition, closing a chapter of more than three decades of UN peacebuilding operations in the east African nation. The transition comes as al-Qaeda-linked Al-Shabaab continues to control large swathes of central Somalia. AFP

ISLAMABAD

Pakistan PM orders fast-tracking of development in Gilgit-Baltistan



AFP

Pakistan Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif has directed officials to accelerate ongoing federal development projects in the controversial Gilgit-Baltistan region and ensure timely release of funds. The development assumes significance for India as Gilgit-Baltistan is illegally and forcibly occupied by Pakistan. PTI

Iran's Supreme Leader warns U.S., Israel against launching new attacks

Trump says he is considering new military action against Iran after the U.S. midterm elections while Netanyahu speaks of a 'historic opportunity' to topple Tehran's govt.; Islamic republic's Army spokesperson warns of 'expanding scope of war'

Agence France-Presse
TEHRAN

Iran's Supreme Leader on Saturday warned the United States and Israel against launching new attacks following their threats to resume strikes after crucial elections.

President Donald Trump has warned of new military action after the U.S. holds midterm elections, saying last weekend he was weighing up whether to "finish them off".

In Israel, Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu has spoken of a "historic, one-time opportunity" to topple the Iranian government.



An anti-Israel board, with '5064 days until the destruction of Israel' written on it, on a street in Tehran, Iran. REUTERS

Both countries are holding legislative polls that could determine the direction of the conflict, with Israel having voted on Tuesday and the U.S. midterms set for next week.

"If the enemies once again launch military or terrorist attacks, it is the armed forces of the Islamic republic and the Iranian nation that will determine the time and conditions for ending them," Iran's Supreme Leader Mojtaba Khamenei said on Saturday in a statement.

'Impactful response'

"Any level or type of threat must be met with an immediate, impactful and geographically unrestricted response," he is said to have told top military commanders in a meeting.

The encounter was the first reported between Mr. Khamenei and military top brass and included armed forces chief of staff Ali Abdollahi, Army chief Amir Hatami and Revolutionary Guards commander Ahmad Vahidi.

The Supreme Leader has not been seen publicly since he took the helm in March after the killing of his father Ayatollah Ali Khamenei in U.S.-Israeli strikes at the outset of the war.

Mr. Khamenei also ordered commanders to update Iran's target list to include "all types of tangible and intangible assets belonging to the American-Zionist enemy".

Earlier on Saturday, Iranian Army spokesperson Mohammad Akaraminia warned that any resumption of hostilities would only expand the scope of the war.

Poland's President accuses PM of taking over top court

Reuters
WARSAW

Polish President Karol Nawrocki on Saturday accused Prime Minister Donald Tusk of staging a forced takeover of the country's top court after the head of the court, an ally of the previous far-right government, was suspended.

Late on Friday, the Constitutional Tribunal said its longest-serving judge Anna Korwin-Piotrowska had suspended Bogdan Swieczkowski, the tribunal's president and an appointee of Mr. Tusk's hard-right predecessor, and was now in charge of the court.

The move escalated a battle between Mr. Nawrocki, an ally of the previous nationalist government, and Prime Minister Donald Tusk's pro-European government over control of the judiciary.

"Tonight, there was a breach of public order in the Republic of Poland and a forcible takeover of a constitutional body," Mr. Nawrocki said in a statement read by an aide outside the court early on Saturday, after the President had turned back mid-flight from a trip to Africa to address the situation.



Bogdan Swieczkowski attempts to enter the headquarters of the Polish Constitutional Court in Warsaw on Saturday. AFP

He headed straight to the court where riot police were out in force as several hundred protesters demanded Mr. Swieczkowski's reinstatement. Mr. Nawrocki called for urgent political consultations.

Mr. Tusk, writing on X, said his government was seeking to restore the rule of law, which the European Union had accused his predecessors – the Law and Justice Party – of subverting.

"This process is difficult, at times even painful, and requires decisive action. There is no other way," he said.

A long-running political dispute over the Constitutional Tribunal has effectively paralysed the institution, with the pro-European government and the nationalist President refusing to recognise appointees put forward by the other side.

The dispute dates back to 2015, when the Law and Justice sought to appoint judges to seats already filled by the previous government.

Earlier this year, Mr. Nawrocki refused to swear in three of six judges nominated by Parliament, while Mr. Swieczkowski declined to seat judges elected by the current parliamentary majority.

Resilient spirit



Children attend a class in a makeshift classroom at a camp for internally displaced people who fled their homes due to renewed clashes, in Abs, Hajjah governorate, Yemen on Saturday. AFP

German police fire water cannon during tense 'Gen Z' protests

Agence France-Presse
FRANKFURT

German police fired water cannon to disperse firework-hurling protesters on Saturday and were also pelted with other projectiles, as tensions rose at the end of massive youth-led protests.

In Berlin, Frankfurt, Cologne and dozens of other cities, demonstrators turned out for the protests organised by the group "GenZ regelt!" (GenZ has got this), the latest by disillusioned youth in Europe.

Thousands of police were deployed across the country and, after mostly peaceful demonstrations, tensions rose in the evening in some places.

The movement's complaints range from the high cost of living to poorly maintained schools, government spending cuts and, what it sees as politicians making decisions with "little regard for the younger generation".

U.S. to deport 150 Afghan immigrants

Agence France-Presse
WASHINGTON

U.S. President Donald Trump's administration plans to deport more than 150 Afghan immigrants back to Afghanistan via Pakistan, *The New York Times* reported on Friday, a move advocacy groups say could endanger their lives.

Among those expected to be deported are relatives of Afghans who assisted the US military in the country prior to the fall of Kabul, according to AfghanEvac, a group seeking to help former Afghan allies.

While the United States cannot arrange deportations directly to Afghanistan, the officials told the *Times* that Pakistan will oversee their expulsion to Afghanistan.

U.S. Secretary of State Marco Rubio declined to comment on the report.

U.S. approves Patriot missile sale to Ukraine

Agence France-Presse
WASHINGTON

The Trump administration on Friday green-lit the sale of 500 Patriot missiles to Ukraine, the State Department said, but the Ukrainian President warned deliveries could take years.

The approval, which goes to Congress for review, comes after weeks of complaints by Ukrainian authorities that its supplies of the interceptor missiles were dwindling.



Volodymyr Zelenskyy

No delivery estimate

"The proposed sale will improve Ukraine's capability to meet current and future threats by improving its integrated air and missile defence capabilities," the Department said.

The statement did not provide an estimate for when the weapons could be delivered to Ukraine.

But Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said late Friday in a post on X that "deliveries may begin ONLY IN A FEW YEARS".

"We are asking our American partners to find a solution for the time when there is a real danger and a real need to use PAC-3 interceptors," Mr. Zelenskyy said, using an acronym for the weapons.

The Ukrainian leader suggested that the U.S. and European allies could give his country missiles they have stockpiled now, which would later be replenished by this new purchase.

Britain open to apologising for slavery, says PM Burnham

Sriram Lakshman
LONDON

U.K. Prime Minister Andy Burnham has said his government is open to the idea of formally apologising for Britain's historical role in the slave trade, although he ruled out financial reparations.

Mr. Burnham set out his position in an opinion piece in *The Guardian* on Friday, ahead of the Commonwealth Heads of Government Meeting (CHOGM) in Antigua and Barbuda, next week. There have, for long, been calls for Britain to apologise and offer reparations for slavery and its colonial past, including in India.

Some 3 million Africans were transported as slaves to work on plantations in Britian's colonies in the Americas. Britain began abolishing the slave trade in its empire in 1807. Slavery was abolished in 1833 though not all slaves were freed until 1838. Britain "compensated" slave owners to a total sum of £20 million or 40% of the government's annual budget in 1833.

"Manchester's cotton industry was built on the labour of enslaved people," wrote Mr. Burnham, the former Mayor of Manchester. He acknowledged the calls from affected countries for a dialogue on slavery. "By sticking our heads in the sand, we have damaged the ability of the Commonwealth to function," he said.

Mr. Burnham said the U.K. was "offering structured dialogue with those affected by the transatlantic slave trade".

"Listening to calls for a formal apology on behalf of the British state will form an important part of this process, and I am open to them," he added.

Calls for Britain to make amends for its past have grown louder in recent days as King Charles III tours the Caribbean on his way to the CHOGM. The King is the titular head of the Commonwealth. In the Bahamas this week, King Charles acknowledged the "great suffering and injustices of the past", stopping short of an apology. Buckingham Palace has said it was up to the U.K. government to decide whether or not to apologise.



British Prime Minister Andy Burnham pushed back against the notion of financial reparations for victims of slavery. REUTERS

Barbadian Prime Minister Mia Amor Mottley welcomed Mr. Burnham's statement, even as she acknowledged that "views differ" on reparations. The British Monarch was the titular Head of State of Barbados until 2021, when the country became a republic. Once slavery was abolished, a system of indentured labour grew in the colonies between 1838 and 1917. Some 2 million men, women and children from India were shipped across the British Empire, from the Caribbean to South Africa, to work on plantations.

Historical wrongs

Mr. Burnham pushed back against the notion of financial reparations for victims of slavery, saying the British people could not be held responsible for historical wrongs "however heinous", that happened in a different age and under different legal circumstances, in which they did not play any part.

Instead, Mr. Burnham announced that former Prime Minister Gordon Brown would head a debt restructuring initiative for some of the poorest countries in the Commonwealth.

Cities like Manchester continued to grow after the abolition of slavery as the British empire consolidated its grip on the markets of its colonies, notably India, which became a supplier of raw cotton to the mills of Manchester, Liverpool, Glasgow and other areas.

Author and Lok Sabha MP, Shashi Tharoor, who has written on British colonialism in India, has been one of those calling for an "atonement" by the U.K. for its past. Mr. Tharoor has previously suggested that a symbolic annual sum of £1 per year be paid to India, for 200 years, as part of this.

"I have long argued that whatever reparations are offered by Britain, no credible figure is payable and no payable figure is credible. But moral atonement for the ravages of colonialism is indispensable," Mr. Tharoor told *The Hindu* on Saturday, when asked for a reaction to the Burnham piece and debate around reparations.

Mr. Tharoor welcomed Mr. Burnham's willingness to formally apologise for slavery but criticised the Prime Minister's omission of a larger apology for colonialism.

"But the omission of colonialism from his apology is inexplicable and inexcusable. It remains deeply shameful that Britain has never said a simple 'sorry' for the loot, pillage, death and destruction perpetrated during the colonial era on millions of innocent victims of British imperialism," Mr. Tharoor said.

PACE ACE

Rabada becomes the fastest to 350 Test wickets in terms of deliveries



AFP

South Africa's Kagiso Rabada on Saturday became the fastest to reach 350 Test wickets in the third Test against Australia. Rabada took 13,808 deliveries, fewer than Dale Steyn (14,719) and Waqar Younis (14,905) to achieve the milestone. He also became the fifth from his country to claim 600 wickets in international cricket.

FIRST BLOOD

Chase and King script West Indies' emphatic victory over Bangladesh



AFP

Brandon King piloted West Indies to an eight-wicket win against Bangladesh in the first Test in Mirpur on Saturday to take a 1-0 lead. Roston Chase took five for 36. **The scores:** Bangladesh 272 & 142 in 48.4 overs (Nayeem 52, Chase 5/36, Warrican 4/63) lost to WI 245 & 170/2 in 35.1 overs (King 81 n.o., Campbell 49). **PoM**: Warrican.

TRIUMPHANT

Fakhar's hundred steers Pakistan past Lanka in the tri-series final



REUTERS

Opener Fakhar Zaman hit a century while Saad Baig and Arafat Minhas smashed half-centuries to take Pakistan past Sri Lanka by three wickets in the ODI tri-series final in Lahore on Saturday. **The scores:** Sri Lanka 325/8 in 50 overs (Kamindu Mendis 131, Pavan 77) lost to Pakistan 331/7 in 48.3 overs (Zaman 127, Baig 74, Minhas 61).

TEAM UPDATE

Nabi to be part of the Indian ODI squad for entire series against NZ



FILE PHOTO: RITU RAJ KONWAR

Auqib Nabi will be part of the Indian ODI squad from the start of the series against New Zealand. The right-arm pacer, who was initially in the squad for the fourth and fifth ODIs, has been brought in after Prasidh Krishna failed to regain fitness. The first match will be played at the Eden Park in Auckland on Wednesday.



Overjoyed: The Australian batters found Harmer too hot to handle on the final day. AP

Harmer the hero as SA clinches series

The spinner's six-wicket haul helps the host bundle out the Aussies for 111; the result sees Bavuma & Co. climb to the top of the ICC Test rankings

AUSTRALIA IN SA

Agencies
CAPE TOWN

Simon Harmer picked up a career-best six for 16 as South Africa bowled out Australia for 111 to win the third Test by 176 runs and clinch the three-match series 2-1 in Newlands on Saturday.

The 37-year-old off-spinner finished with match figures of 10 for 120, his first 10-wicket haul in Tests. Harmer's second innings figures read: 21.1-14-16-6.

Kagiso Rabada took three for 39 to reach 350 Test wickets.

Set a 288-run target, Australia collapsed to 60 for seven at lunch before Nathan Lyon (33 not out) and captain Pat Cummins (11) offered some resistance.

The visitors had a tough morning session as Kagiso Rabada and Harmer took three wickets each.

The day began with Australia getting off to a poor start as Rabada dismissed the in-form Matt Renshaw for a golden duck, caught behind down the leg-side.

Australia's previous lowest fourth innings total against South Africa was 107 – also at Cape Town – back in 2018, when it lost by 322 runs. With the win, South Africa replaced Australia at the top of the ICC Test rankings.

The scores:
South Africa 329 & 387 bt Australia 429 & 111 in 57.1 overs (Harmer 6/16).
Player-of-the-Match: Harmer.
Player-of-the-Series: Jansen.

WTC Points Table

		P	W	L	D	DED*	PTS	PCT
1	New Zealand	6	4	1	1	0	**52**	72.22
2	South Africa	7	5	2	0	0	**60**	71.43
3	Australia	13	9	4	0	0	**108**	69.23
4	India	11	5	4	2	0	**68**	51.52
5	Bangladesh	7	3	3	1	0	**40**	47.62
6	England	16	7	8	1	14	**74**	38.54
7	Sri Lanka	6	1	2	3	0	**24**	33.33
8	West Indies	13	3	8	2	2	**42**	26.92
9	Pakistan	9	2	7	0	19	**5**	4.63

Points system: 12 for a win, 6 for a tie, 4 for a draw

The teams are ranked according to the percentage of points (PCT) won and the top two progress to the final in 2027

***Deductions:** Points are deducted for slow over rates

Will Sooryavanshi, Kuldeep feature in the final T20I?

INDIA IN NZ

Press Trust of India
HAMILTON

Even though the Indian team management is steadfast in its backing of the established line, the Auckland shellacking might have triggered thoughts of making some tactical rejigging to the playing XI in the fifth and final T20I against New Zealand here on Sunday.

India has an unassailable 3-1 lead, but the World champion would certainly not want to sign off with a defeat after dominating the early part of the five-match series.

In that context, the think-tank will ponder whether to bring back Vaibhav Sooryavanshi and the obvious casualty will be Sanju Samson.

The bowling department, too, has its own issues to deal with despite keeping the Kiwis to below 200 in the second and third T20Is.

India has been heavily reliant on Arshdeep Singh and to a lesser extent Axar Patel for wickets and control after the much-celebrated return of Bhuvneshwar Kumar failed to yield results.The only way to bring in either Kuldeep Yadav or Varun Chakaravarthy is to bench Naman Dhir.

India's spin-bowling coach Sairaj Bahutule had said that both Kuldeep and Varun were ready to step in any time, even though that chance might not come their way in this series. The home side will take a lot of heart from the efforts of century-maker Glenn Phillips and Michael Bracewell, who made a power-packed fifty, going into this match.

It will however, require another huge effort to narrow the margin of defeat.

Match starts at 12.30 p.m. IST.



Mixed bag: Sooryavanshi fell cheaply in one match and sparkled in the other. CREIMAS/BCCI

It's all in the mind, says Manisha

WRESTLING

Y.B. Sarangi

An ardent Cristiano Ronaldo fan, Manisha Bhanwala values time like her superstar idol. After a frustrating Asian Games outing, she made the best use of the short period to bounce back as the first-ever Indian woman wrestler to land a World championship gold in Astana.

Manisha had planned to compete in 59kg, instead of Olympic category 57kg, in order to avoid another round of weight cut. "It was not my day at the Asian Games. Our coach (Virender Dahiya) told me that something big was awaiting me. Since I had less time, I chose 59kg," said Manisha at a virtual press conference organised by the Wrestling Federation of India on Saturday.

Manisha, hailing from Siwaha village in Jind district of Haryana, joined one of her role models, 2010 World champion Sushil Kumar, in an exclusive club after staging a remarkable come-from-behind 8-6 win over USA's Abigail Elizabeth Nette in the final. For Manisha, who paid an emotional tribute to her late father Suresh for his support by posing with a T-shirt featuring his photograph alongside her Worlds belt, it was a dream-come-true. "I started wrestling late. So, I couldn't take the belt as a junior or sub-junior. Now I have the belt," said Manisha, who led the Indian women to the fifth spot in the team rankings.

Having won international medals in four different weight categories - 57kg, 59kg, 62kg and 65kg - the 29-year-old does not feel insecure of the talented Indians in 57kg. "There's nothing called old or young. It's all in the mind. You must take care of your diet and sleep."

Eager to make a mark in 57kg at 2028 Los Angeles Olympics, Manisha looked on the bright side of winning the World title in a non-Olympic weight. "Some wrestlers who would switch to 57kg were here. Competing with them was an advantage," she said.



Manisha with a T-shirt carrying her father's photo.

> I started wrestling late. So, I couldn't take the belt as a junior or sub-junior

Qualifier Swara sizzles

WTT FEEDER

K. Keerthivasan
CHENNAI

With her loose-fitting jersey, Swara Karmarkar could easily be mistaken for a sub-junior paddler. But the diminutive 16-year-old from Nashik, ranked 947th in the world, is far more accomplished than what her ranking suggests.

Swara, coached by Jay Modak, has started making significant strides at the international level. On Saturday, she produced a fine show to storm into her maiden women's singles semifinals in the WTT Feeder Chennai at the TN Physical Education and Sports University here.

Armed with a hook serve that often earns her easy points, Swara possesses an attacking forehand and uses a defensive long-pimpled rubber on her backhand. She displayed her repertoire in the win over Suhana Saini in the quarterfinals.

The teenager, a qualifier here, will face second seed Yoo Yerin of South Korea while Sutirtha Mukherjee will meet top seed Yang Ha Eun of South Korea.

Among men, G. Sathiyan will meet Manav and SFR Snehit will take on England's Samuel Walker.

There were some stunning results in the pre-quarterfinals. P.B. Abhinandh, who had shocked the No. 4 seed, went down to qualifier Nikunj Attri while Suhana got the better of fourth seed Nithya Shree Mani in the women's section. The biggest shock was the exit of Ankur Bhattacharjee, the second seed, who lost to Walker.



Swara... on a roll.

The results: Men (quarterfinals): Manav Thakkar bt Harmeet Desai 5-11, 11-4, 12-10, 13-11; G. Sathiyan bt Yashansh Malik 11-3, 11-9, 11-3; SFR Snehit bt Nikunj Attri 11-9, 11-9, 4-11, 11-6 Samuel Walker (Eng) bt Payas Jain 14-16, 5-11, 11-5, 11-7, 11-9; **Doubles (semifinals):** Sathiyan & Harmeet bt Sanil Shetty & Snehit 5-11, 9-11, 11-7, 11-1, 11-4; Payas & Priyanuj Bhattacharyya bt Ankur Bhattacharjee & Akash Pal 4-11, 11-9, 6-11, 11-8, 11-8.

Women (quarterfinals): Sutirtha Mukherjee bt Divyanshi Bhowmick 11-9, 11-13, 11-8, 11-7; Yang Ha Eun (Kor) bt Lee Haelin (Kor) 11-9, 11-9, 11-6; Swara Karmarkar bt Suhana Saini 11-9, 6-11, 11-8, 8-11, 11-4; Yoo Yerin (Kor) bt Avisha Karmakar 11-5, 11-5, 11-2.

Mixed doubles (semifinals): Mehan Senthil & Ananya Muralidharan bt Kwon Hyuk & Kim Seoyun (Kor) 11-7, 11-9, 6-11, 7-11, 11-7; Manav Thakkar & Taneesha Kotecha bt Payas & Sayali Wani 11-6, 12-10, 10-12, 11-7.

Jurel and Padikkal lift India-A on the opening day

Press Trust of India
CHRISTCHURCH

Skipper Dhruv Jurel made a solid unbeaten 99 after Devdutt Padikkal's breezy 80 as India-A recovered well to score a strong 291 for seven against New Zealand-A on the opening day of the four-day match here on Saturday.

Jurel (99 batting, 155b) and Akash Deep (25 batting) were at the crease at close. The eighth-wicket pair has so far added 69 in 18.4 overs.

At lunch, India-A was comfortably placed at 87 for one despite the early dismissal of Yashasvi Jaiswal, who trapped leg-before by pacer Fraser Sheat in the first over.

India lost Sai Sudharsan (41) in the first over after lunch.

But Padikkal continued unfazed, bringing up a sturdy fifty in 101 balls with a boundary through point off Jarrod McKay.

India-A was 131 for two at this stage, but the Kiwis snared three wickets in quick time.

However, Jurel found a willing ally in Manav Suthar (22) as the seventh wicket duo added 62.

The scores: India-A 291/7 in 88 overs (Padikkal 80, Jurel 99 batting, Sheat 4/80) vs. New Zealand-A. **Toss:** NZ-A.

Brighton hands City second loss; Chelsea adds to United's woes

EURO LEAGUES

Reuters
LONDON

Brighton inflicted a second straight Premier League defeat on Manchester City with a 1-0 win to close within two points of the leader on Saturday, while Manchester United slumped to another damaging defeat for Michael Carrick at Chelsea.

Third-placed Brighton ended its wait for a first-ever away win against City at the 18th attempt to bolster dreams of challenging for the title.

Earlier, United looked lively in the first half but squandered a series of chances. It was punished four minutes into the second half when Morgan Rogers picked up the ball just inside the United half and cantered past a hesitant defence before delicately lifting it past goalkeeper Senne Lammens.



Despair: Nothing seems to be going right for Carrick & Co. REUTERS

Lisandro Martinez gave away a penalty and was shown a second yellow card in the 63rd minute. Cole Palmer scored from the spot to make it 2-0.

The results: Premier League: Chelsea 2 (Rogers 50, Palmer 64-pen) bt Manchester United 0; Bournemouth 2 (Evanilson 31, Adli 90+5) bt Leeds 0; Brentford 2 (Milenkovic 30-og, Thiago 76) bt Nottingham Forest 0; Coventry 3 (Sakamoto 17, Awoniyi 37, Rudoni 52) bt Sunderland 1 (Le Fee 67-pen); Hull 2 (Iroegbunam 58, McBurnie 68) drew with Ipswich 2 (Fiorentino 22, Enciso 74); Manchester City 0 lost to Brighton 1 (Ayari 11).

LaLiga: Levante 0 lost to Atletico Madrid 2 (Grimaldo 36, Simeone 62); Rayo Vallecano 3 (De Frutos 36, 55, Lopez 73) bt Celta Vigo 0.

Seria A: Bologna 2 (Pobega 33, Bernardeschi 59-pen) bt Monza 1 (Varela 6-pen).

On Friday: LaLiga: Villarreal 0 lost to Espanyol 1 (Cabrera 60).

Bundesliga: Elversberg 4 (Keidel 7, Onyeka 26, Krattenmacher 45+1, Campbell 90+1) bt Mainz 1 (Hollerbach 90+2).

Sindhu, Lakshya book spots in title clash

BADMINTON

Press Trust of India
SAARBRUCKEN

P.V. Sindhu and Lakshya Sen set up a double title bid at the $500,000 Hylo Open Super 500 badminton tournament after cruising into the women's and men's singles finals with straight-game victories on Saturday.

Double Olympic medallist Sindhu, who finished runner-up at the French Open last week, continued her impressive run with a 21-13, 21-16 win over World No. 53 Anmol Kharb in a lopsided all-Indian semifinal to reach her second final in as many weeks.

The former world champion will face Denmark's eighth seed Line Hojmark Kjaersfeldt in the final.

Later, Lakshya, who has been going through a rough patch since reaching the All England final this year, notched up a stunning 21-17, 21-13 win over World No. 13 Toma Junior Popov in the semifinal.

The 25-year-old from Almora, a 2021 World championships bronze medallist, will take on the winner of the other semifinal between fourth seed Jonatan Christie of Indonesia and top seed Anders Antonsen of Denmark.



Lakshya. FILE PHOTO: SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR

Navy ends Railways' title hopes, enters the final

The three-time defending champion bows out after a penalty shootout as Rajbeer and Darshan miss their attempts; BPCL gets the better of Army via a tie-breaker to reach the summit clash

MURUGAPPA GOLD CUP

S. Prasanna Venkatesan
CHENNAI

Indian Railways' quest for a fourth consecutive title was derailed as Indian Navy knocked out the defending champion 4-2 in a penalty shootout in the first semifinal of the 97th all-India MCC-Murugappa Gold Cup hockey tournament at the SDAT Mayor Radhakrishnan Stadium here on Saturday.

The teams were locked 2-2 in regulation time.

BPCL also advanced to the final, pipping Indian Army in a penalty shootout.

Navy, the runner-up last year, held its nerve in the shootout, with goalkeeper Ankit Malik playing a key role. Railways, meanwhile, will rue its poor conversion rate, having converted just one of the eight penalty corners it earned. Navy made the most of its only penalty corner.

After a goalless first quarter, Navy took the lead in the 27th minute through Yogesh Singh, who converted Abhishek Topno's penalty-corner delivery with a drag-flick.



Stellar show: Goalkeeper Ankit and Selvaraj were the architects of Navy's win over Railways. R. RAGU

Railways drew level in the third quarter through Pratap Lakra's drag-flick off a penalty corner. Atul Deep put Railways ahead in the 55th minute, scoring off a rebound after goalkeeper Sanjay Bhaskar had blocked Lovepreet Singh's close-range attempt.

Navy forced a shootout with three minutes left when K. Selvaraj converted Sanjit Toppo's long diagonal pass in the 57th minute.

Navy scored through Ashis Topno, Sanjit Toppo, Yogesh, and Kuldeep in the shootout, while Rajbeer Singh and Darshan Gawkar missed for Railways.

The results (semifinals): Indian Navy 2 (Yogesh Singh 27-pc, K. Selvaraj 57) drew with Indian Railways 2 (Pratap Lakra 39-pc, Atul Deep 55). Navy won the shootout 4-2.

Indian Army 1 (Akshay Dubey 27-pc) drew with Bharat Petroleum Corporation Ltd. 1 (Anmol Ekka 55-pc). BPCL won the shootout 4-1.

Feisty Southern derby between CFC, KBFC ends in goalless draw

ISL

Sankar Narayanan E.H.
CHENNAI

The fans came out in numbers. The chants came in vociferous waves, both from the Marina Machans and the travelling Manjappada.

The only missing piece of the puzzle was a goal. The Jawaharlal Nehru Stadium waited with bated breath for the net to ripple. That goal, though threatened to arrive on several occasions, never actually materialised as Chennaiyin FC and Kerala Blasters FC played out a feisty 0-0 draw in the Indian Super League on Saturday.

Golden opportunity

Following a first half dominated by the host, Blasters squandered a golden chance when Adrian Luna's penalty hit the post and went wide in the 51st minute.

The spot-kick had come after Irfan Yadwad handled the ball. Luna, however, could not capitalise despite sending Mohammad Nawaz the other way.

Blasters once again challenged Nawaz, this time through Andre Green's shot from inside the box. The Chennaiyin custodian was up to the task, pulling off a superb diving save.



Narrow miss: Irfan came close to breaking the deadlock for Chennaiyin in the second half. R. RAGU

Emmanuel Imanishimwe tested Amrinder Singh from close range when the ball fell kindly for the CFC defender off a corner. Irfan thought he found the net and started celebrating when his delightful curler beat Amrinder's extended hand. The ball, however, could only rattle the woodwork.

The frustration finally boiled over, with CFC's Emmanuel (second yellow) and KBFC's Green (straight red) getting sent off in injury time for a heated brawl.

Both teams, after the hard-fought contest, went towards their section of fans in acknowledgement of the celebratory mood. The Southern derby indeed had everything except a goal.

The results:
At Chennai: Chennaiyin FC 0 drew with Kerala Blasters FC 0.
At Kolkata: Mohun Bagan SG 2 (Lee Erwin 18, Dejan Drazic 42) bt Punjab FC 1 (Alfred Planas 3).

Indian wrestlers disappoint

Sports Bureau

Indian freestyle wrestlers ended their World championships campaign in Astana without a medal on Saturday. Jaspooran Singh (125kg) beat Jamaican Aaron Johnson 10-0 in repechage, but lost 0-10 to USA's Wyatt Hendrickson in the bronze match. Nikhil (61kg) and Pushpender Dalal (86kg) lost their respective repechage bouts.

BTC Stewards, Committee Members, BoA members elected

BENGALURU: The following were elected Stewards, Committee Members and Board of Appeal members for 2026-27 at the 65th Annual General Meeting of the Bangalore Turf Club (BTC) held on October 30 in Bengaluru:

Stewards: K. Jayaram, Kenneth Pinto and R. Manjunath Ramesh.
Committee Members: K. Kamesh and Shanker Sreenivas.
Board of Appeal Members: Y. Jagannath, Satish N. Gowda, Vivek G. Ubhayakar, Byriah Siddaramu and Sidney Moses.

IOA's new election Code of Conduct

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

No criticism of opponents' "private lives", bar on all forms of publicity, including the use of new media and social networks, and a requirement for IOA and NSF office-bearers to maintain neutrality feature in the Model Code of Conduct for the upcoming elections to the Athletes' Commission and Sportspersons of Merit (SOMs).

The election to pick 10 members of the Athletes' Commission of the Indian Olympic Association will be held on Nov. 3, while the polls to choose eight SOMs will be on Nov. 9.

LIVE TELECAST

New Zealand vs. India: Fifth T20I, Sony Sports Ten 1 & LIV, 12.30 p.m.

ISL: Sony Sports Ten 2 & LIV, 5 & 7.30 p.m.

Hockey: Asian Champions Trophy, India vs. Malaysia, SS Select 2 & JioHotstar, 7 p.m.

Premier League: SS Select 1 & JioHotstar, 10 p.m.

Formula One: Mexico GP, F1 TV, F1 TV Pro App & FanCode, 1.30 a.m. (Monday).

New Zealand-A vs. India-A: Second 'Test' Day 3, Sony Sports Ten 1 & LIV, 3.30 a.m. (Monday)

Asian Champions Trophy hockey badly in need of a total overhaul

Uthra Ganesan
JALANDHAR

Halfway through the men's Asian Champions Trophy and the difference between India and the rest of the participating teams has been more evident than ever.

While it was always expected that the host would dominate the proceedings, the huge gap on the turf merits question on the relevance of the competition, specially for India, and the way forward for both the ACT and Asian hockey.

When the event was conceptualised and inaugurated way back in 2011, it was meant to be an avenue for Asian teams to compete against and grow with each other. Since then, however, continental hockey has only slipped further on the world stage, reflected in the world rankings.

Consider this: At the end of 2011, when the ACT was first played, there were three Asian teams in the top-10 – Korea (6), Pakistan (8) and India (10). Malaysia (13), Japan (15) and China (17) weren't too far behind. A year later, Pakistan broke into the top-five followed by Korea and India as the highest-ranked Asian sides.



A cut above the rest: The gulf between India and the other Asian teams has widened. X@THEHOCKEYINDIA

In contrast, the latest rankings (as of Saturday) have India (8) as the lone Asian team in the top 10 – as has been the case for the last few years – with Pakistan (12), Malaysia (13) and Japan (16) following. Korea is languishing at 20.

India has been the only Asian team to qualify for all the four Olympics since then. Pakistan played the 2012 edition by virtue of winning the 2010 Asian Games and Japan was at the 2020 edition as host. Korea's last appearance at the quadrennial showpiece was in 2012.

"Well, I see this tournament as possibly a building phase for certain teams. It's really difficult to place it somewhere where it has meaning when you've just played Asian Games against the same people, so it is difficult," coach Craig Fulton admitted.

One way of raising the tournament's profile and make it more competitive could be expanding it beyond Asia. Making it an Afro-Asian or Asia-Oceania competition with eight to 10 teams instead of the present six would not only bring in better teams but also provide much needed impetus to Hockey India's plans of diversifying the hosting of international hockey across the country.

There is no denying, however, that the tournament in its entirety, its place in the calendar and Asian hockey as a whole needs a revamp. Hockey India secretary general Bholanath Singh, also the AHF vice-president, did not respond to queries despite repeated attempts.

A chance for Vaishnavi, Maaya and Sahaja to show their mettle

TENNIS

Nihit Sachdeva
CHENNAI

For Indian tennis players, appearances in the main draws of Tour-level events come at a premium. Therefore, cashing in when a rare window of opportunity opens up is important.

When the main draw of the third edition of the WTA 250 Chennai Open begins at the SDAT Stadium on Monday, Vaishnavi Adkar, Maaya Rajeshwaran and Sahaja Yamalapalli will look to make the most of the wild cards awarded to them. The 21-year-old Vaishnavi, the country's No. 1 player and ranked 334 in the WTA rankings, will be up against Jodie Burrage, the 27-year-old Brit who has entered the main draw via a Protected Ranking of 149.

"Playing as India No. 1 is not really what I'm focusing on right now. I just want to improve my game," said Vaishnavi during Saturday's draw ceremony.



All in readiness: The third edition of the WTA 250 Chennai Open is upon us. NIHIT SACHDEVA

The 17-year-old Maaya faces Polish World No. 106 Katarzyna Kawa while 26-year-old Sahaja takes on Swiss World No. 128 Simona Waltert.

Indonesian World No. 47 Janice Tjen, the reigning champion, meets former Junior US Open champion and American wild card Katherine Hui.

The tournament has been hit by a spate of withdrawals in the last few days. As many as seven players pulled out either due to injury, illness or the change in their schedule.

"The tournament draw is very heavy in the middle. It is wide open and anyone can win it," said Vijay Amritraj, president of the Tamil Nadu Tennis Association.

India's Jensi Kanabar, Zeel Desai, Shrivalli Bhamidipaty, and Diya Ramesh bowed out in Qualifying.

Sheetal Iyer (WTA Supervisor), Hiten Joshi (CEO, Tamil Nadu Tennis Association), Panna Udvardy (Hungarian player), Amritraj, Vaishnavi, B. Venkatasubramanyam (secretary, TNTA) were present for the ceremony.

India eyes an improved show against Malaysia

Uthra Ganesan
JALANDHAR

Already assured of a spot in the semifinals with three wins in as many games, unbeaten India and Malaysia will face-off in a potential battle for the top spot on the Asian Champions Trophy points table here on Sunday but with very different targets in mind.

India had a wake-up call against a resilient Japan and Saturday's break would help Craig Fulton's boys to refresh, regroup and relook at their performance. Even though India has had the upper hand against Malaysia over the past decade – its last defeat came in the 2018 Asian Games semifinals in the shootout - the Speedy Tigers have always been tricky opponents.



Shining bright: Abhishek was the standout player while Vishnukant too found the target against Japan. HOCKEY INDIA

A stroke of luck and the lone penalty corner in the final quarter helped the home team break the shackles against Japan. "Sometimes when you play a lot of easy games, it just kind of changes perspective and you think you're just going to walk in and beat everyone by six-seven goals. And it (the challenge) is good. You don't always get what you want and you have to find a way," Fulton admitted.

India will also hope to cut down on the mistakes that marred its previous outing. Sanjay and Jarmanpreet need to get more disciplined in the defence. The midfield struggled to find openings against the Japanese. Abhishek, who struck twice, agreed it was much-needed. "Yes, it was a wake-up call. Japan played well, but if we play to our plan, I am sure we can do better against Malaysia," he said.

The last time the two teams met was in the final of the recent Asian Games which India won 5-1 to qualify for the LA Olympics.

"We don't just look to finish in top two but we want to close the gap with the big teams," Malaysia head coach Brendon Carolan said.

Petronas TVS' Chiranth reigns in Super Sport 301-400cc Open class

MOTORSPORTS

Sports Bureau
CHENNAI

Bengaluru's Chiranth Vishwanath breezed to victory in the premier Super Sport 301-400cc Open class, upstaging pole-sitter and Petronas TVS Racing teammate Sarthak Chavan in the third round of the MRF Indian National Racing Challenge 2W 2026 at the Madras International Circuit, here on Saturday.

The results: Provisional (six laps unless mentioned): Super Sport 301-400cc Open: Race 1: 1. Chiranth Vishwanath (Petronas TVS Racing, 10m, 55.474s); 2. Sarthak Chavan (Petronas TVS Racing, 10:55.989); 3. Rakshith Dave (Petronas TVS Racing, 10:57.703).
Pro-Stock 200cc Open: Race 1 (3 laps): 1. Savion Sabu (MadRabbit Racing, 06:08.259); 2. Senthil Kumar (Team Rockers Racing, 06:08.611); 3. K. Amarnath Menon (MadRabbit Racing, 06:09.103).
Super Stock 301-400cc Open: Race 1: 1. Senthil Kumar (Team Rockers Racing, 11:26.600); 2. S. Mathana Kumar (Team Rockers Racing, 11:26.761); 3. Kabilesh Rajini Krishnan (RACR Castrol Power 1, 11:29.135).
Super Stock 165cc Intermediate: Race 1: 1. K.K. Anandhu (Veedol C2 Racing, 12:48.674; 2. D. Annish Samson (Motul Sparks Racing, 12:53.960); 3. Faruk Ali Sohtun (Motul Sparks Racing, 12:58.202.
Stock 301-400cc Novice: Race 1: 1. K.K. Anandhu (12:15.654); 2. S. Venugopalan (Motul Sparks Racing, 12:15.713); 3. Divy Parmer (Ipone Yakuza Racing India, 12:16.338). **Stock 165cc Novice: Race 1 (4 laps):** 1. Surya Reddy (RACR Castrol Power 1, 08:49.529); 2. Yashwant Varma (Motul Sparks Racing, 08:49.923); 3. K.M. Saranjith (Veedol C2 Racing, 08:50.023.
Petronas TVS one-make Championship: Expert (Apache RR 310): Race 1: 1. R. Hari Haran (11:33.103); 2. Rajender Beedani (11:33.771); 3. Kamal Navas (11:43.181).
Rookie (Apache RTR 200) Race 1: 1. Jangam Akarsh (13:12.423); 2. Dev Agastya (13:12.650); 3. C. Godwin Clarance (13:12.862).
Women (Apache RTR 200): Race 1 (5 laps): 1. Poojitha Anil Kumar (11:15.136); 2. Drishya Nair (11:27.312); 3. Hannah Akkineni Joshitha (11:31.698).



Chiranth.



A withered sweet lime tree in an orchard in Anantapur. A prolonged deficit in rainfall has triggered a severe crisis in the region that heavily depends on borewells for horticulture cultivation. Growers are looking up to the government for help to bail them out of the crisis.

Bitter times for Seema's sweet lime farmers

Farmers growing sweet lime face mounting losses as water scarcity, triggered by a deficit in rainfall and depleting groundwater levels, threatens orchards across several mandals in Rayalaseema region of Andhra Pradesh; the crisis has pushed cultivators into severe financial distress, raising concerns about the economic future of sweet lime cultivation and its impact on the livelihoods of those dependent on the crop, writes **G.V.R. Subba Rao**

The sweet lime trees that farmers in Rayalaseema have tended to for years are drying up, their survival depending on a few drops of water. With borewells running dry and a prolonged rainfall deficit, farmers in and around the Santhanuthalapadu mandal are watching their orchards wither, even as they spend thousands of rupees on water tankers. For many cultivators, the struggle to keep their crops alive has become a costly gamble, with mounting debts and little assurance of a return on their hard labour.

Standing under the glaring sun beside their drip-irrigation lines, farmers in traditional *dhotis* and duster towels look out at their withering orchards with deep concern, as a deepening water crisis threatens to wipe out the livelihoods they built around sweet lime cultivation.

Among those struggling to save their orchards is 30-year-old Bhaskar Naik from the Nagulagudam thanda (hamlet) in Anantapur district. "Mounting financial distress, severe water scarcity, and widespread crop loss have left many families in deep distress," he says.

Narrating his ordeal, he explains how the lack of irrigation water has devastated his nine-year-old sweet lime orchard and pushed him into a debt trap. "The absence of adequate irrigation water has resulted in the complete drying up of nearly four acres of my orchard over time. At present, only around three acres are alive, while the trees in the remaining area are on the verge of drying up," he says.

With the trees drying up, Bhaskar Naik says he is also struggling to recover the money invested in the cultivation. "I have incurred debts of approximately ₹6 lakh for borewell drilling and other expenses since I started growing sweet lime about nine years ago. The annual expenditure is around ₹2.5 lakh, but I earned approximately ₹4 lakh from two crops harvested in a single season only once. Since then, the shortage of water has resulted in severe losses, leaving me struggling to recover my investment," he adds, a strain clear in his voice.

In a desperate bid to save his surviving trees, he is trying to bring water from a canal through a pipeline. The project requires around 600 pipes, each costing ₹850, making it an additional expense for the debt-ridden family.

With a heavy heart, he shares that he has been borrowing money at an interest rate of 2 per cent per month and has been paying interest for the past six years. Despite making regular payments, he is unable to repay the principal, as his limited resources are barely sufficient to meet the interest liability.

> I have incurred debts of approximately ₹6 lakh for borewell drilling and other expenses since I started growing sweet lime about nine years ago. The shortage of water has resulted in severe losses and I am struggling to recover my investment,
>
> **BHASKAR NAIK,** Farmer

Search of water

Bhaskar Naik's struggle is not an isolated case; the worsening condition of the orchards points to a much deeper problem—the depletion of groundwater. A prolonged deficit in rainfall has triggered a severe crisis in a region that heavily depends on borewells for horticulture cultivation.

Farmers have drilled repeatedly in search of water, but depleting groundwater levels have rendered many of these investments futile. Even where borewells continue to function, the water available is often insufficient to meet the needs of extensive orchards.

In Marthadu village, Garladinne mandal, farmers are spending heavily on borewell drilling and tanker supplies in a desperate attempt to protect their trees.

Highlighting the scale of the crisis, Andhra Pradesh Rythu Sangham State Secretary K. Prabhakar Reddy, who led a team of farmers' association representatives to inspect the affected orchards, states that sweet lime cultivation covers approximately 91,000 acres in Anantapur district, including 19,000 acres in Garladinne mandal alone. Nevertheless, rising temperatures and declining groundwater levels have left farmers struggling to keep these trees alive—orchards that took years of care to mature, he adds.

This water crisis is hitting farmers hard in their pockets. Some farmers have spent up to ₹5 lakh drilling six consecutive borewells without finding a single drop of water. With repeated drilling proving completely unsuccessful, expensive tanker supplies have become their desperate and unsustainable last resort.

For Sugali Bhaskar Naik, who owns a three-acre sweet lime orchard, water tankers have become the last resort to save his crops. He shares that he has spent nearly ₹3 lakh over the past three to four years on the orchard, at an estimated cost of ₹80,000 an acre.

"With the borewells failing to yield water and no alternative source available, I have been hiring four to five water tankers a day for the past two days, spending around ₹4,000 to ₹5,000 daily," he says.

The expenditure has added to his financial distress at a time when the absence of rain and the drying up of crops have made it difficult for him to support his family.



The consequences go beyond this season's loss. The farmers' association points out that Venkata Ramana of Nagalgudem in Singanamala mandal of the district has lost a five-acre sweet lime orchard, while Yeruswamy, of the same mandal, has seen eight acres of his orchard dry up due to a lack of water. With their investments wiped out and debts mounting, they say they are left in a helpless position. "I have borrowed around ₹10 lakh to maintain the orchards, and I am now struggling to repay the loans and meet interest payments to private lenders," says another grower hit by the crisis.

Bleak future

The problem is not limited to just one mandal. Similar stories of despair are emerging from Putlur, Bukkarayasamudram, and other mandals.

The plight of cultivators in Chennampalli, Garuvuchintalaapalli, and Jangamareddypeta villages of Bukkarayasamudram mandal in the Singanamala Assembly constituency has drawn attention to the worsening drought conditions in Rayalaseema.

> The government must pay compensation for completely dried-up orchards, provide direct financial assistance, offer subsidies for replacement saplings and agricultural inputs,
>
> **M.V.S. NAGI REDDY** Former A.P. State Agricultural Mission vice-chairman

Farmers like Ram Mohan Reddy and Maheswar Reddy have watched their sweet orange trees—locally known as *bat-thayi*—wither and die despite years of care and intense financial investment. While some cultivators are desperately attempting to keep their trees alive by drawing water from whatever meager sources remain, others have been forced to confront the heartbreaking reality that their orchards cannot be saved.

For orchard farmers, water scarcity is particularly severe because a seasonal crop failure may mean losing one harvest, but losing an established fruit orchard represents years of expenditure on saplings, irrigation systems, fertilizers, and labour. When mature trees die, farmers must clear the damaged orchard, plant new saplings, and wait several more years before substantial returns begin. The immediate loss is compounded by the income they would have earned during that period.

A look at the official data shows just how widespread this crop is and why so many families are worried. According to sources in the Agriculture Department's third advanced estimates for 2025-26, Anantapur district leads the State with 48,260 hectares under sweet lime cultivation, followed by Kadapa with 35,946 hectares and Sri Sathya Sai district with 17,853 hectares. Meanwhile, Markapuram accounts for 2,864 hectares, Kurnool for 2,699 hectares, Nandyal for 1,354 hectares, Nellore for 1,349 hectares, and Palnadu for 937 hectares. In total, the area under sweet lime cultivation in Andhra Pradesh stands at 1,13,251 hectares, with a staggering 24.5 lakh tonnes of production originating from Rayalaseema alone.

With so much at stake, A.P. Rythu Sangham leader Prabhakar Reddy warns that this relentless water shortage threatens not just sweet lime orchards, but the survival of all horticultural crops across the region.

The deficit rainfall this year has compounded farmers' financial problems, forcing many to rely on borrowings to dig more borewells or to depend on water tankers, as there are no flowing streams from which to draw water.

Another cultivator, who is also struggling to cope with the crisis, remains optimistic and hopes that things will eventually work out. His 12-year-old sweet lime orchard, spread over four acres, is on the verge of drying up after his borewells ran dry. He says he spent nearly ₹5 lakh drilling three borewells this past year in a desperate effort to save the orchard, but failed to find water. He is now spending around ₹3,000 a day on tankers, with no certainty about how long he can sustain the expense.

Similarly, farmer Venkata Reddy suffered a total loss of his sweet lime crop spread over three acres due to the water shortage. His damaged orchard was among those inspected by the association's representatives, who heard similar accounts from other cultivators in the village.

The distress points to a larger economic crisis within the community. Farmers generally incur expenditures of around ₹40,000 to ₹50,000 per acre during the first five years of sweet lime cultivation. The money goes toward saplings, drip irrigation systems, fertilizers, and labour, while substantial returns usually begin only after the trees mature. The loss of an established orchard, therefore, wipes out both the initial investment and the income expected from subsequent harvests.

All hopes on the government

With their livelihoods at stake, farmers have turned to the government for help. However, despite repeated appeals, they allege that they have not received adequate support.

Looking to the State government with anticipation, farmers are urging officials to treat the drying orchards as an agricultural emergency and provide immediate protective irrigation measures for vulnerable trees. They demand that the government bear 75 per cent of the expenses incurred for supplying water through tankers.

Former Andhra Pradesh State Agricultural Mission vice-chairman M.V.S. Nagi Reddy seeks mandal-level inspection teams to document the damage and identify farmers requiring urgent assistance. He demands that the government pay compensation for completely dried-up orchards, provide direct financial assistance, offer subsidies for replacement saplings and agricultural inputs, and grant relief on agricultural loans. He also urges the government to arrange drinking water and fodder for livestock in affected areas and declare Rayalaseema an emergency drought region with a special relief package for farming families.

The consequences of the crisis extends beyond individual farming families. Horticulture supports agricultural labourers, farm machinery owners, transport operators, traders, and food-processing units, while supplying fruit to domestic and export markets. A prolonged decline in production could therefore disrupt livelihoods throughout the agricultural supply chain.

For the farmers, however, the immediate concern is whether their trees will survive long enough to yield another crop. Every day spent purchasing water through tankers adds to their costs, while every tree that dries up reduces the possibility of recovering years of investment. Without timely relief and a dependable source of irrigation, many cultivators face the prospect of starting again with new saplings, fresh borrowing, and several years of waiting for an income.

The drying orchards have exposed the vulnerability of a horticultural economy built on long-term investment but dependent on increasingly uncertain water supplies. For farmers who have spent years nurturing their trees, saving the remaining orchards is now as much a struggle to protect their livelihoods as it is an effort to preserve the region's horticultural wealth.

They urge the government to intervene immediately, assess losses, and provide compensation to help them recover from the severe water crisis.

Lethal joyrides

The back-to-back incidents of youngsters causing deaths on roads with their speeding vehicles have raised alarm bells in Keralam; **G. Ragesh** meets the bereaved family members and law enforcement officers to discuss the worrying trend











A cost too big: (Clockwise from top) Bhadra Keerthi and Bharat Sankar, daughter and son of Jayabalakrishnan, who was killed after a car hit his scooter, stage a protest at the Cheranalloor police station; forensic experts collecting evidence from the accident site; the scooter and the car involved in the Nedumbassery accident.R.K. NITHIN, THULASI KAKKAT, AND SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

A distraught Bhadra Keerthi sat on the road right in front of the Cheranalloor police station on the outskirts of Kochi city in Keralam's Ernakulam district late in the night on October 25, 2026.

The beaming floodlight overlooking the station and its premises fell on her face, cutting through a thick cover of darkness, a tall iron gate and a posse of police who guarded it.

Occasionally, she burst into tears. The next moment, an unbreakable resolve flashed across her face. She was sitting in protest, seeking justice for her father, whose life was cut short by a speeding car.

She was not alone that night. Barefooted, she sat amid a group of people, including her brother, Bharath Sankar, who held her hand.

The siblings had found themselves in a situation no one would ever want to encounter- sitting in front of a police station late at night and shouting slogans even as the embers on their father's pyre were still glowing in a crematorium, a few kilometres away.

The last ride

It was raining on that fateful night.

Before heading home, Jayabalakrishnan had carefully placed the packets of rice and groceries in his scooter. Unaware of what awaited him en route, Jayabalakrishnan, who had been running a wayside eatery at South Chittur in Kochi, left for home in a hurry.

But he couldn't make it to his home that night.

He was allegedly knocked down by a speeding luxury car driven at a speed of 100 kmph by a 17-year-old boy, son of a district judge, at Marapparambu on the Container Terminal road on October 25.

Rice and groceries lay strewn all over the road beside his mangled scooter. A meal that was never cooked spoke of the misfortune that befell the family.

What deepened the sorrow and invited the protest of the bereaved family was the fact that the minor was let off from the police station on bail even before Jayabalakrishnan's cremation.

"The boy who killed our father was let off even before the cremation was over because he is the son of a judge," says Bhadra, seething with resentment.

Her steely resolve to seek justice for her deceased father forced the government to transfer the Kochi City Police Commissioner, suspend four police officers of the Cheranalloor police station, re-apprehend the boy and book a case against his father.

The Cheranalloor case is seen as a rerun of another road tragedy that claimed three young lives just two weeks ago at Nedumbassery.

On October 11, a 19-year-old college student, allegedly in an inebriated condition, mowed down three youngsters. The luxury car driven by Suhail Sajeev, according to the police, was blasting down the highway at a speed of over 165 kmph, while hitting the scooter in which the youngsters were travelling.

Iyas of Coorg in Karnataka, Devika from Wayanad and Gopika from Palakkad, who were all working part-time at an antique shop, perished in the incident.

In both incidents, teenagers from affluent families are the accused, while the victims were from the low-income group who toiled to make both ends meet. The two fatal incidents dashed the hopes of four poor families.

"My daughter was pursuing a six-month programme in data analytics in Kochi. She worked part-time to fund her studies and was planning to go abroad. The accident has shattered our hopes," says M.R. Pradeep Kumar, the father of Gopika.

"The financial condition of Devika's family is even worse. Her father is an estate labourer, and the family had to sell off most of their 30-cent property for her studies. Iyas's father is an aged man with serious ailments," Pradeep Kumar says.

Two days after the Cheranalloor incident, a 17-year-old boy died in Kulathupuzha of Kollam after his bike hit an electric post. The same day, a 16-year-old boy also died in a similar incident at Kozhikode.

Visuals on social media

The repeated incidents suggest a growing penchant for driving among teenagers, fuelled by various factors, including early exposure to vehicles, peer pressure and social media influence. The accused in both the Nedumbassery and Cheranalloor cases had allegedly shared visuals of them over-speeding on social media, a possible indication of their passion for speed.

Police data on underage drivers reveal a scary picture. As many as 488 accidents were reported in Keralam in the past five years, from 2022 to 2026 (till October), killing 92 and grievously injuring 350 others. Luck was on the side of 148 people, who survived with minor injuries. The number of accidents involving minor drivers has been steadily increasing in the State, according to data from the State Crime Records Bureau. The number was 76 in 2022, which rose to 83 in 2023. From 96 in 2024, it went up to 114 in 2025 and 119 in 2026 (until October).

> Instead of dissuading children from driving and sensitising them to its consequences, some parents are encouraging them
>
> **BIJU ISAC**
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Declining numbers

However, the number of cases booked by the Motor Vehicles Department (MVD) against juveniles for the offence paints a different picture.

The numbers, it seems, are on a decline during the past five years. While 57 such cases were booked in 2022, it dropped to 40 in 2023 and 22 in 2024. It further declined to 15 in 2025 and 12 in 2026 (till October).

Biju Isac, Regional Transport Officer (Enforcement), Ernakulam, fears that a larger number of such cases may be going unnoticed. "Often minors venture out to roads close to their residences where checking may not be taking place," he says.

The officer blames the attitude of a section of parents for permitting their children to be at the wheel early. "Instead of dissuading children from driving and sensitising them to its consequences, some parents are encouraging them," he observes.

Driving without a valid licence and driving by an underage person is an offence punishable under Section 181 of the Motor Vehicles Act (MV Act), which attracts a punishment of three months of imprisonment or a ₹5,000 fine or both, the officer notes. Minors causing accidents will be barred from applying for a driving licence until they turn 25, Biju explains.

He also suggests installation of more number plate detection cameras, as part of increased vigil. Drivers shall be made aware that they are being watched on every road, he says.

Legal provisions

Section 199A of the MV Act stipulates that if an offence has been committed by a juvenile, the guardian of the juvenile or the owner of the vehicle shall be deemed to be guilty of the offence and liable to be punished.

However, if they prove that the offence was committed without their knowledge or that they exercised all due diligence to prevent the commission of such offence, they will not be held liable. In the Cheranalloor case, the father of the boy, an Additional District and Sessions Judge, has been arraigned as an accused and questioned by the police. The boy was initially booked under Section 106 (1) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS) for causing death by negligence. Later, Section 105 of the BNS (culpable homicide not amounting to murder) was also added following public protests. The accused in the Nedumbassery case also faces trial under Section 105.

The fatal incidents have rekindled the memories of another case involving IAS officer Sriram Venkitaraman. The Kerala High Court had the other day stayed the trial in the 2019 case in which a journalist, K.M. Basheer, was killed when an over-speeding car, allegedly driven by Sriram, fatally knocked him down in Thiruvananthapuram.

Drunk driving

The Nedumbassery accident also calls for a serious look into drunk-driving cases in the State. The young driver had allegedly consumed alcohol five times higher than the permissible limit at the time of the accident, as reportedly revealed in his blood tests.

According to Kerala Police data, accidents related to drunk-driving increased from 149 in 2024 to 180 in 2025. The number of persons grievously injured in such cases increased from 51 to 103, while fatalities rose from 17 to 23 during the period.

The police have booked 15,782 people for drunk driving during a 15-day special drive following the Nedumbassery incident. The police also launched a special campaign against underage driving and have booked parents allegedly responsible in such cases reported from Thiruvananthapuram, Pathanamthitta and Kozhikode.

Officials from National Transportation Planning and Research Centre (NATPAC) note that accidents caused by behavioural issues appear to be on the rise.

"Speed is a main causative factor in these accidents. The Indian Roads Congress recommends speed for different category of roads based on the terrain. Road owning agencies such as National Highway Authority of India and Public Works department restrict speed in many sections based on situations such as presence of schools, junctions and accident history. Motorists need to be educated that the speed limits are fixed and signs are marked based on scientific studies and evidence," they say.

Meanwhile, NATPAC has inspected the accident spot at Nedumbassery and ruled out structural issues of the road, it is learnt. A similar inspection is likely in Cheranalloor also.

While official data reflect only the number of the dead and the injured in such cases, a larger, grim picture of minors endangering the lives of others and themselves through illegal and irresponsible acts emerges.

Economic angle

Pradeep Kumar, who lost his daughter, however, believes that there is an underlying economic angle too in these cases. The "arrogance of the rich," he feels, shattered the lives of four poor families.

"Often the culprits in such cases, who are influential, find ways to escape while the victims' families are plunged into grief and despair," says Pradeep Kumar as he empathises with the bereaved family of Jayabalakrishnan.

The blood spilt on the roads calls for justice, for the dead and the survivors.